



ENZO MARI
autoprogettazione?



Edizioni Corraini

PROPOSTA PER UN'AUTOPROGETTAZIONE

A project for making easy-to-assemble furniture using rough boards and nails. An elementary technique to teach anyone to look at present production with a critical eye.

(Anyone, apart from factories and traders, can use these designs to make them by themselves.

The author hopes the idea will last into the future and asks those who build the furniture, and in particular, variations of it, to send photos to his studio at 10 piazzale Baracca, 10 - 20123 Milan).

© project Enzo Mari, 1974

The first edition of the book "Proposta per un'autoprogettazione" was compiled by the Duchamp centre and printed for the exhibition at the Galleria Milano in 1974.

Enzo Mari
"autoprogettazione?"

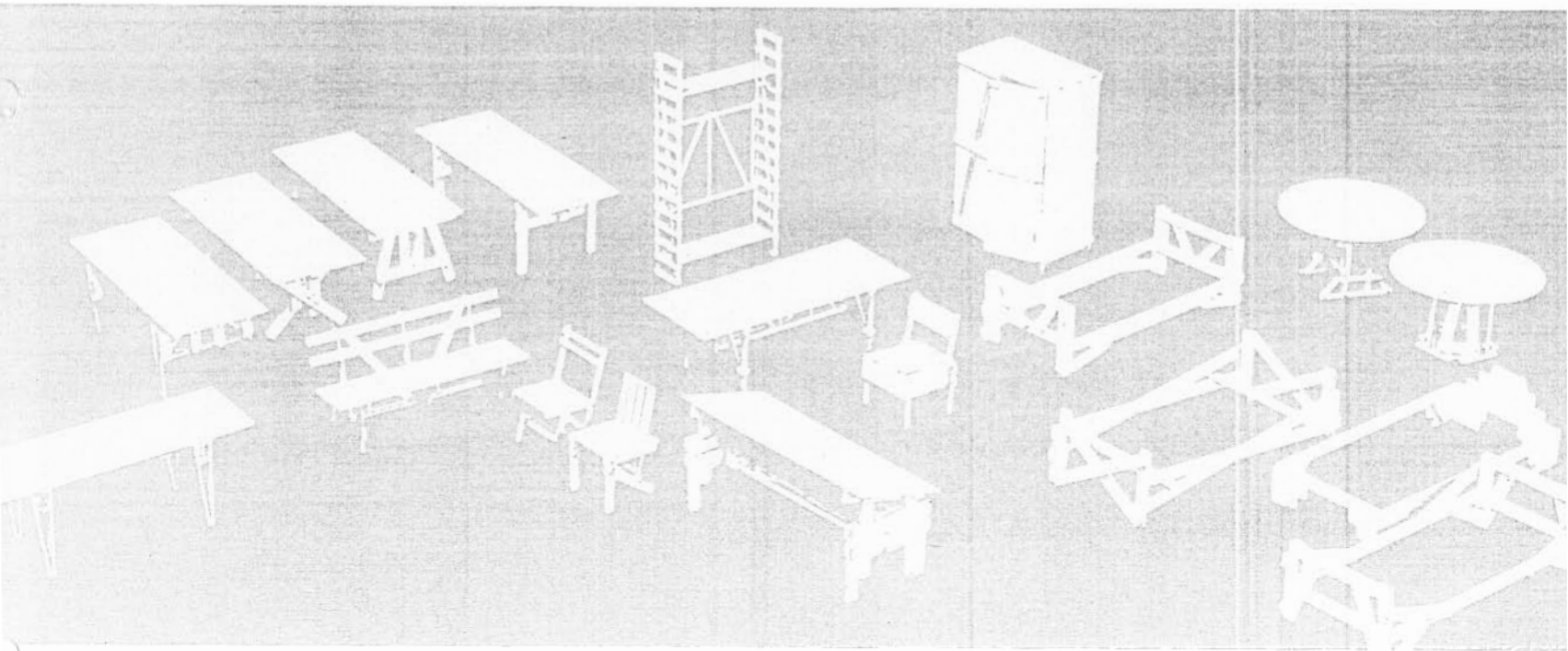
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ENZO MARI

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The quality-quantity ratio is central to the whole of industrial production: quality is determined when the shape of a product does not "seem" but simply "is".

This statement, anything but a paradox, is not however understood by most people. And this makes it particularly difficult to execute projects of real worth. As a result, whenever possible I try to involve people not only with words but "other" deeds.

In 1974 I thought that if people were encouraged to build a table with their own hands, for example, they would be able to understand the thinking behind it. This is why I published the "Proposta per un'autoprogettazione"*.

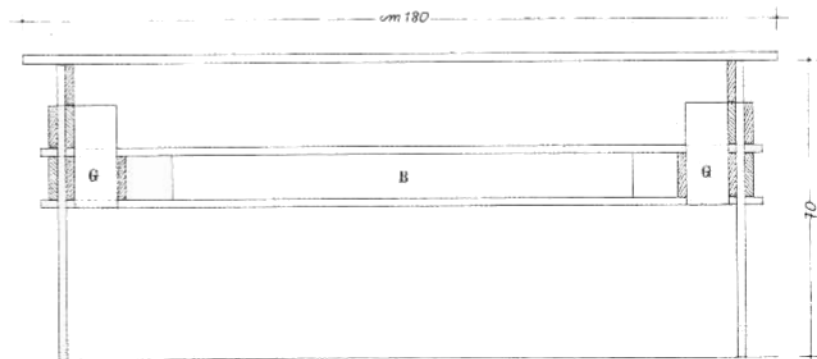
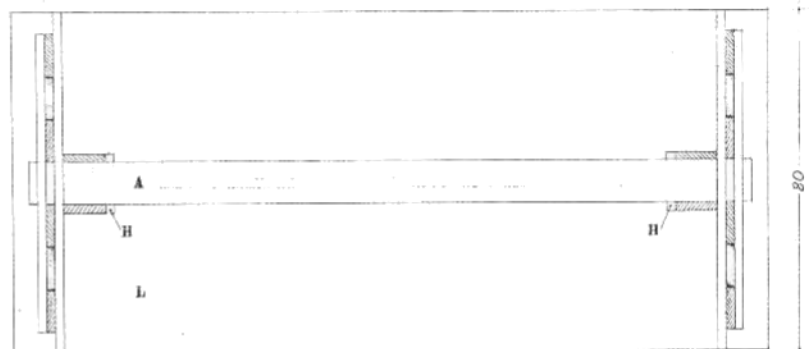
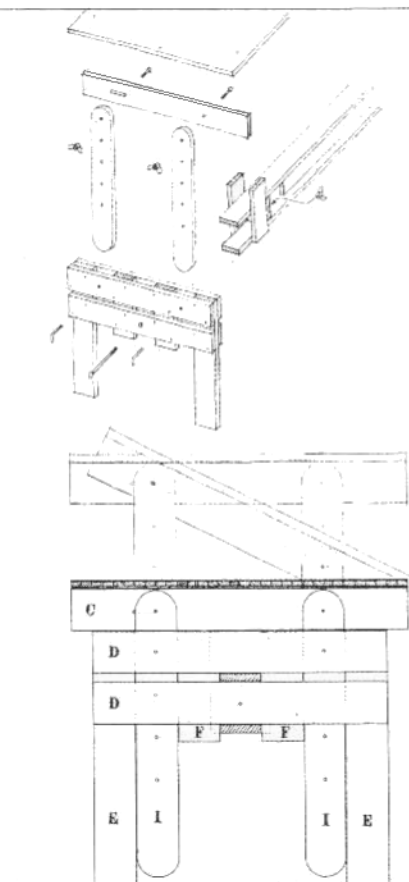
Although people took part at the time, in large numbers and with enthusiasm, the reasons that had pushed me to carry out the proposal certainly have not changed: in fact they have worsened. This is why I want to thank the new editor for this re-edition which in addition to all the iconographical material of the first also contains texts published in the years

immediately afterwards. The first is a collection of articles, interviews and letters published in the exhibition catalogue *Avanguardia e culture popolari* at the Galleria d'Arte Moderna in Bologna in May 1975. The second is my explanation of the reasoning behind the project and its outcome in the book "Enzo Mari", compiled by Arturo Carlo Quintavalle for the Centro studi e archivio della comunicazione in Parma, published in 1983.

I feel it is useful now to add a few technical hints to those texts.

Enzo Mari, June 2002

* It is not easy to translate into English the Italian word *autoprogettazione*. Literally it means *auto* = *self* and *progettazione* = *design*. But the term '*self-design*' is misleading since the word '*design*' to the general public now signifies a series of superficially decorative objects. By the word *autoprogettazione* Mari means an exercise to be carried out individually to improve one's personal understanding of the sincerity behind the project. To make this possible you are guided through an archetypal and very simple technique. Therefore the end product, although usable, is only important because of its educational value.

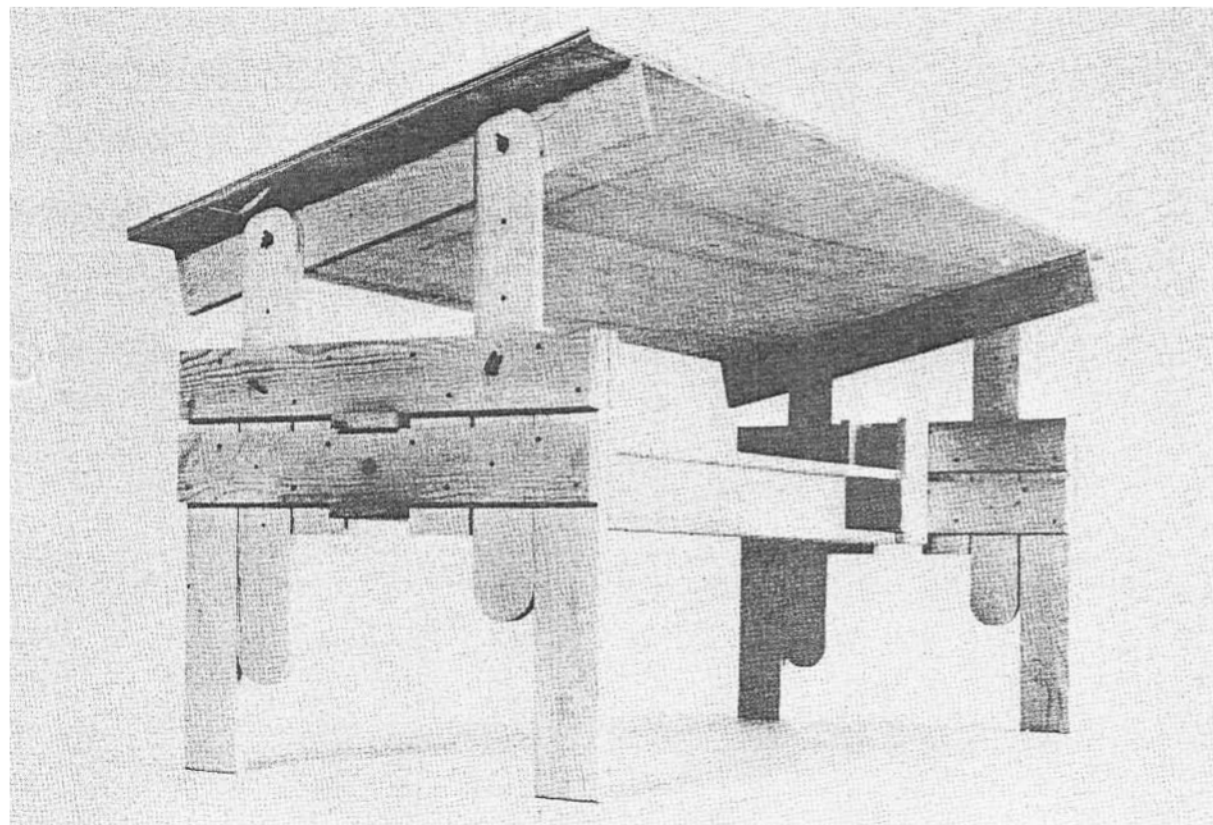


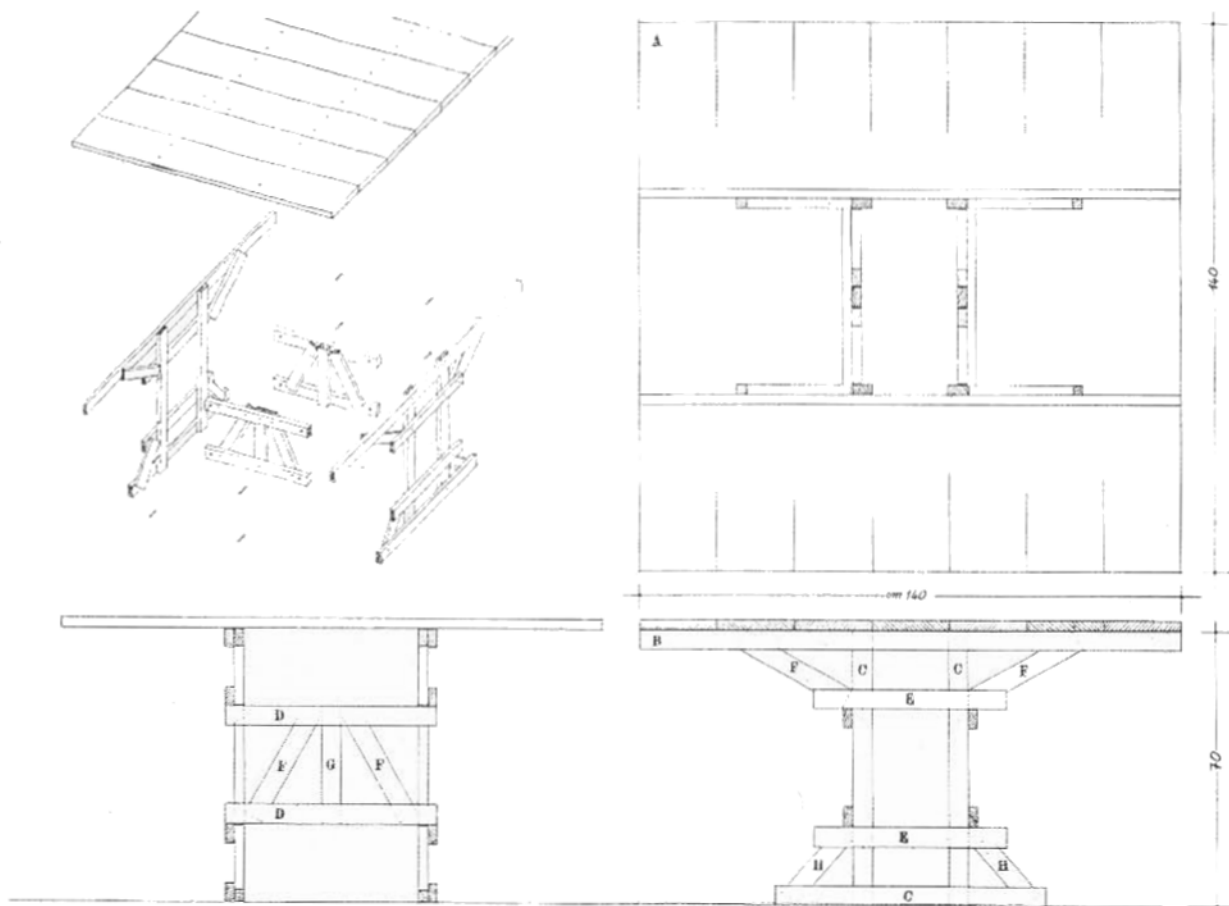
TAVOLETTE OCCORRENTI

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
A	2x10	173 2
B	"	110 1
C	"	80 2
D	"	70 8
E	"	60 4

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
F	2x10	26 4
G	"	24 4
H	"	14 2
I	1,8x10	67 4
L	2x80	180 1

1125 x G	SCALA 1:5	5/73
TAVOLO AD ALTEZZA VARIABILE		
ENZO MANI PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 20123 MILANO TELEFONO 4539851		



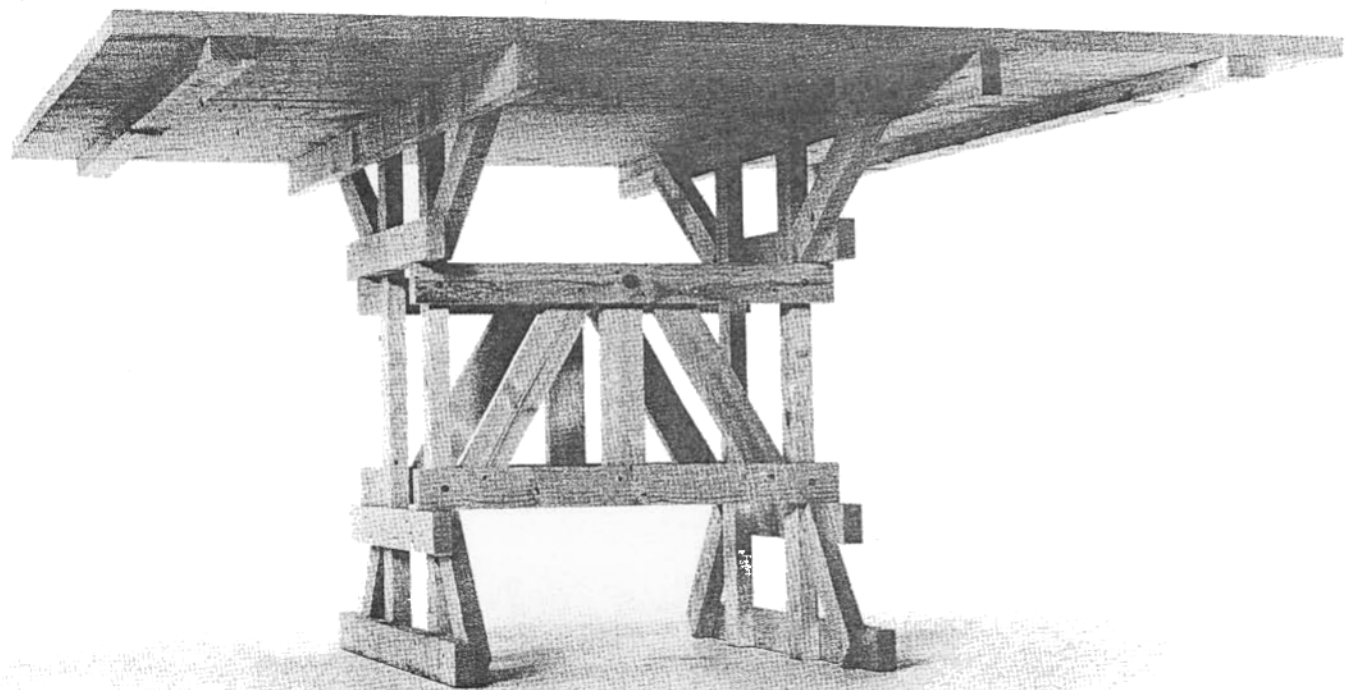


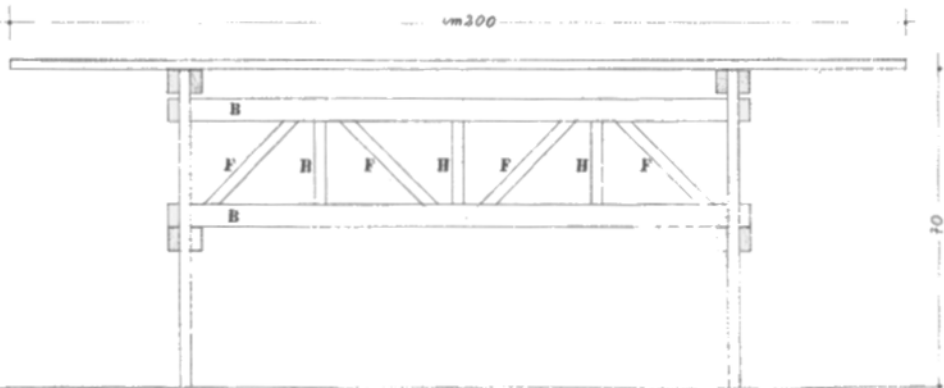
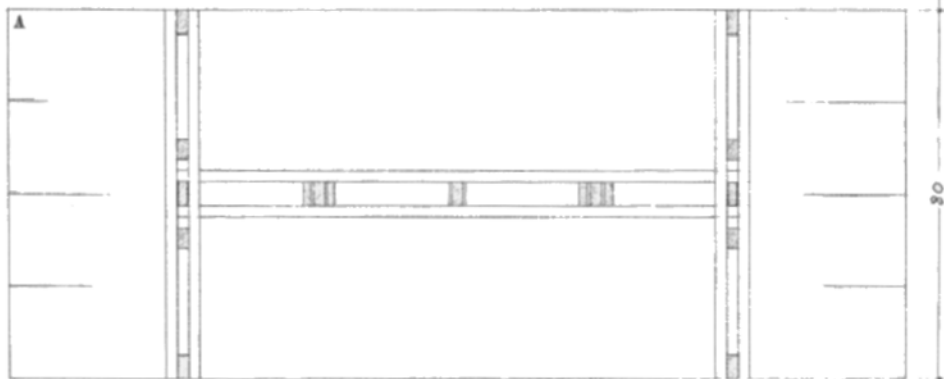
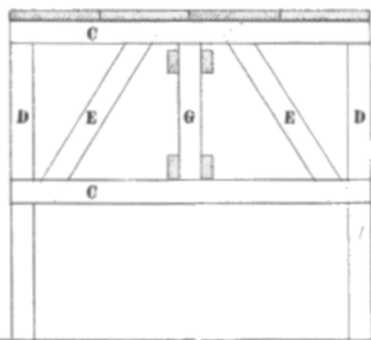
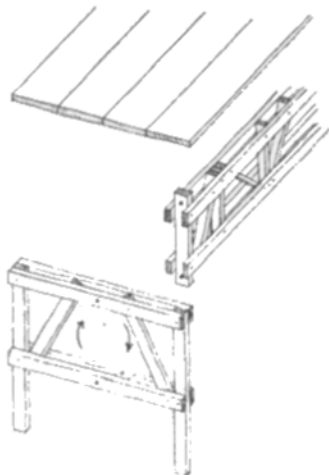
(VIOLETTE OCCORRENTI)

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
A	2,5x20	140 7
B	2,5x5	140 2
C	"	70 5
D	"	55 4
E	"	50 4

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
F	2,5x5	31 8
G	"	30 2
H	"	22 4

1123 X1	SCALA 1:5	5/98
TAVOLO QUADRATO		
ENZO MARI - PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 - 20123 MILANO - TELEFONO 4681051		



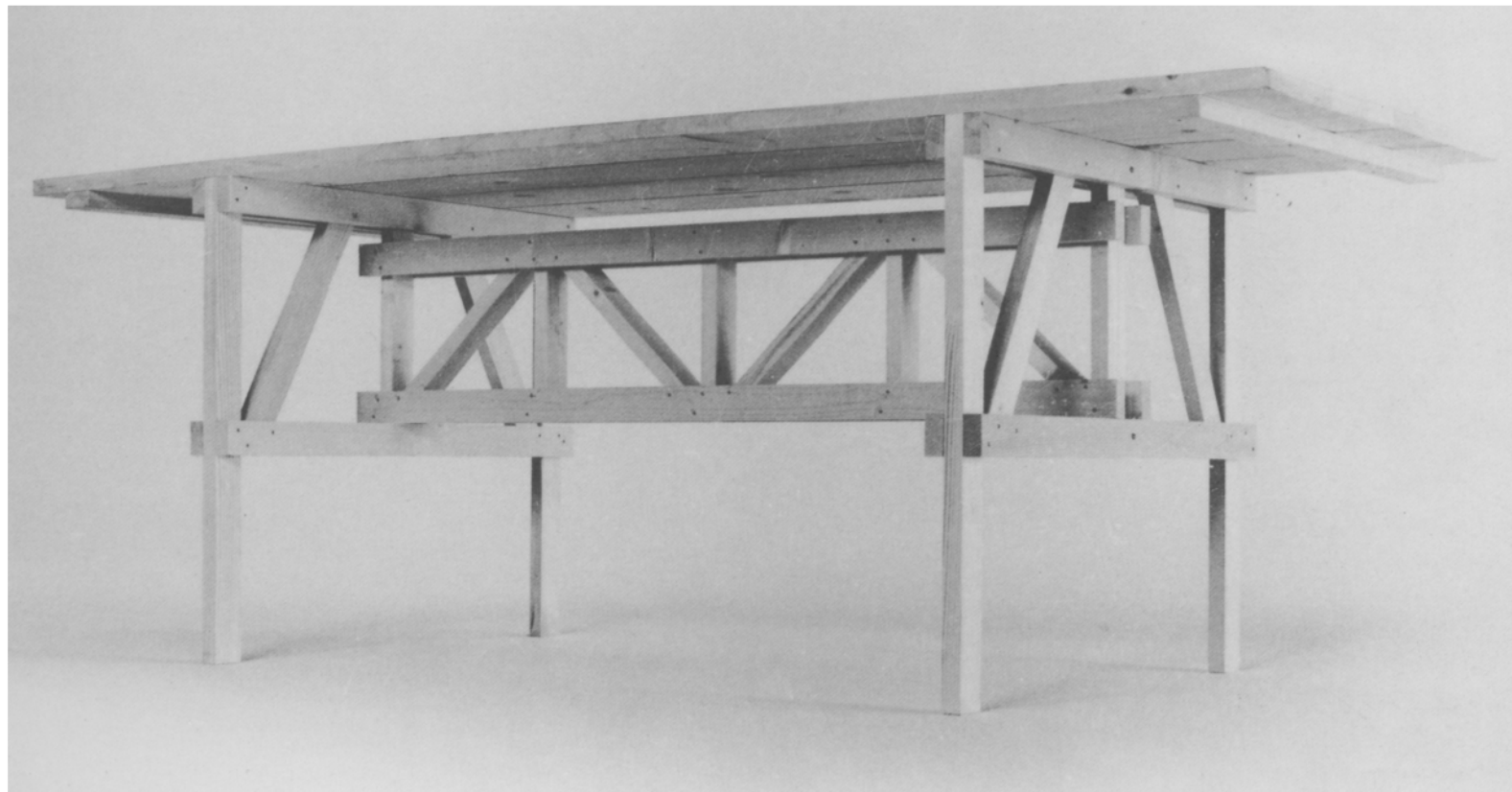


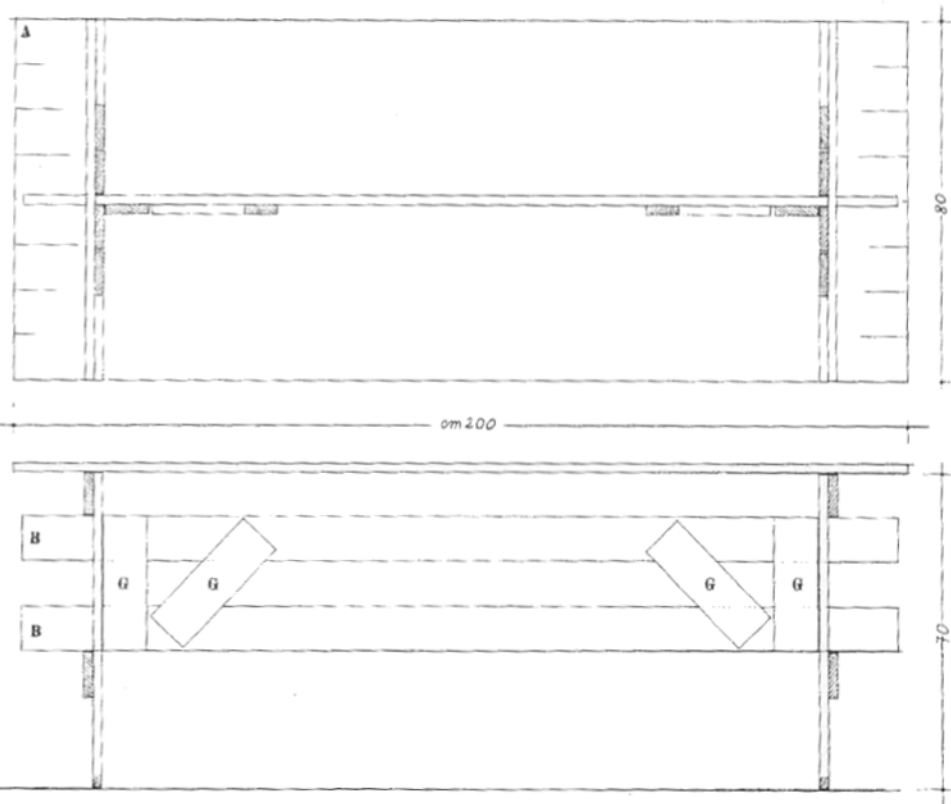
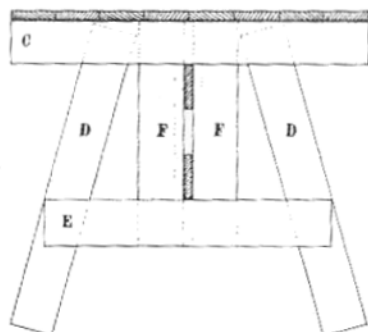
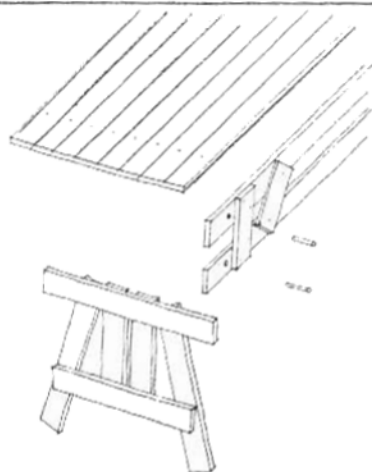
TAVOLETTE COLORATE

DESIGNE	UNITE	QUANTITA'
A	2,5 x 20	200
B	2,5 x 5	130
C	"	80
D	"	70
E	"	43

DESIGNE	UNITE	QUANTITA'
F	2,5 x 5	36
G	"	39
H	"	28

1123 x F	SCALA 1:5	2/2
TAVOLO RETTANGOLARE		
ENZO MANI - PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 - 20123 MILANO - TEL. 02/4000001		



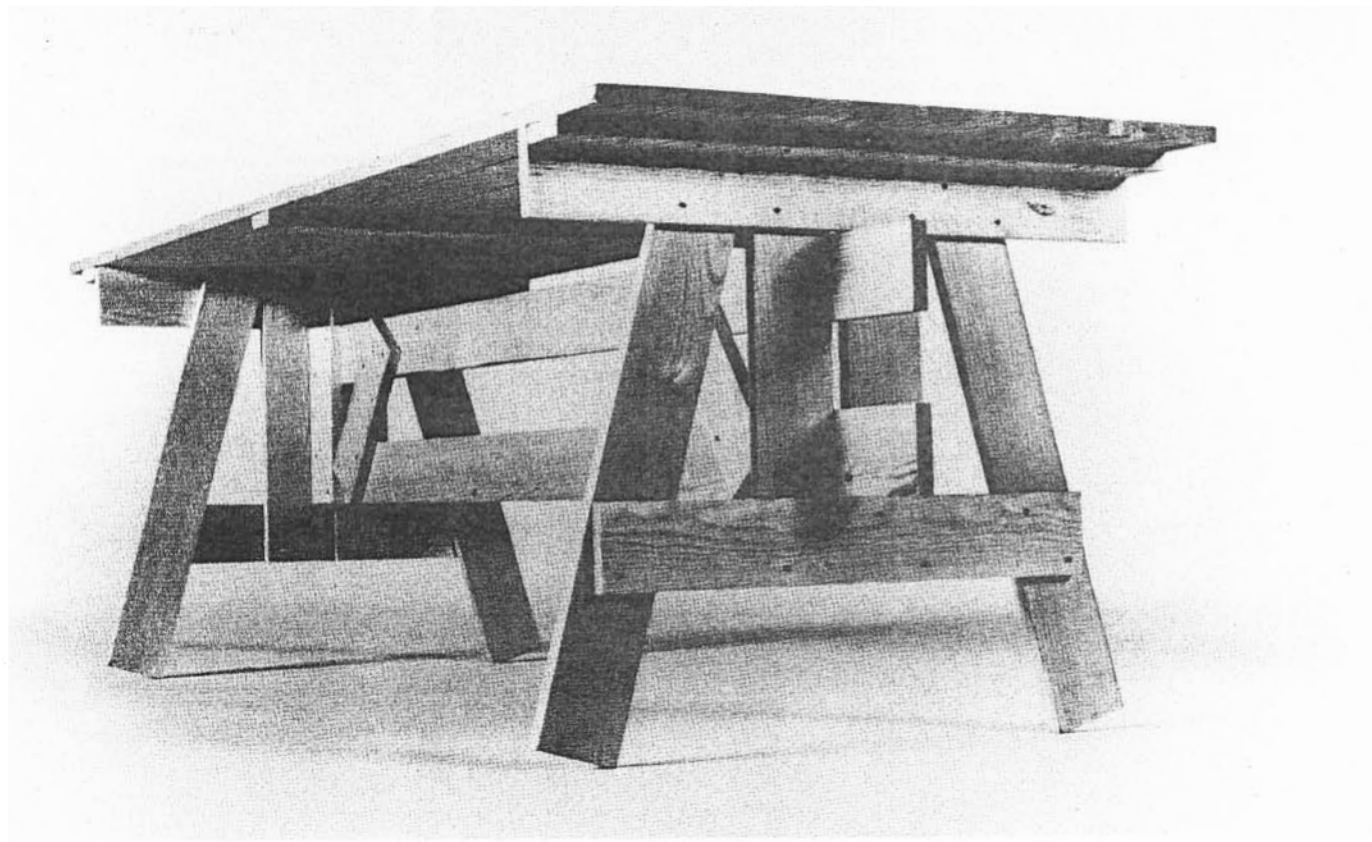


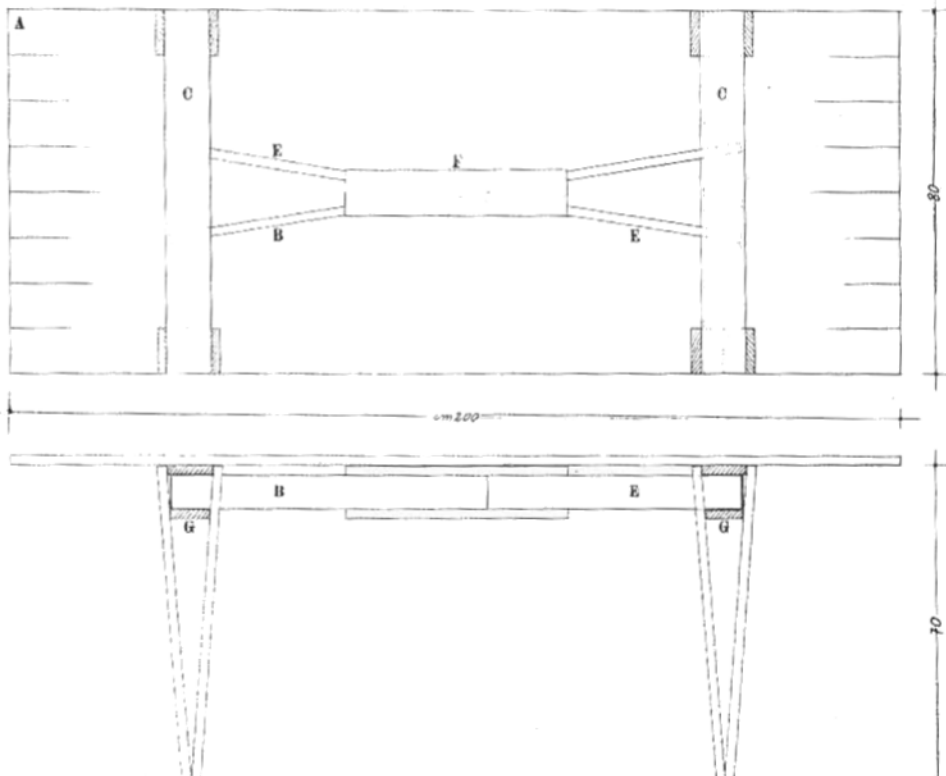
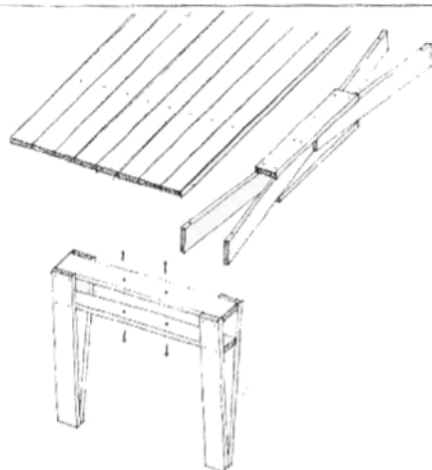
TAVOLETTE DISCONNESSIBILI

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
A	2x10	200
B	"	196
C	"	80
D	"	69
E	"	64

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
F	2x10	50
G	"	30

1123 x B	SCALA 1:5	5/73
TAVOLO RETTANGOLARE		
BIZZI MANI - PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 - 20123 MILANO - TELEFONO 4893881		



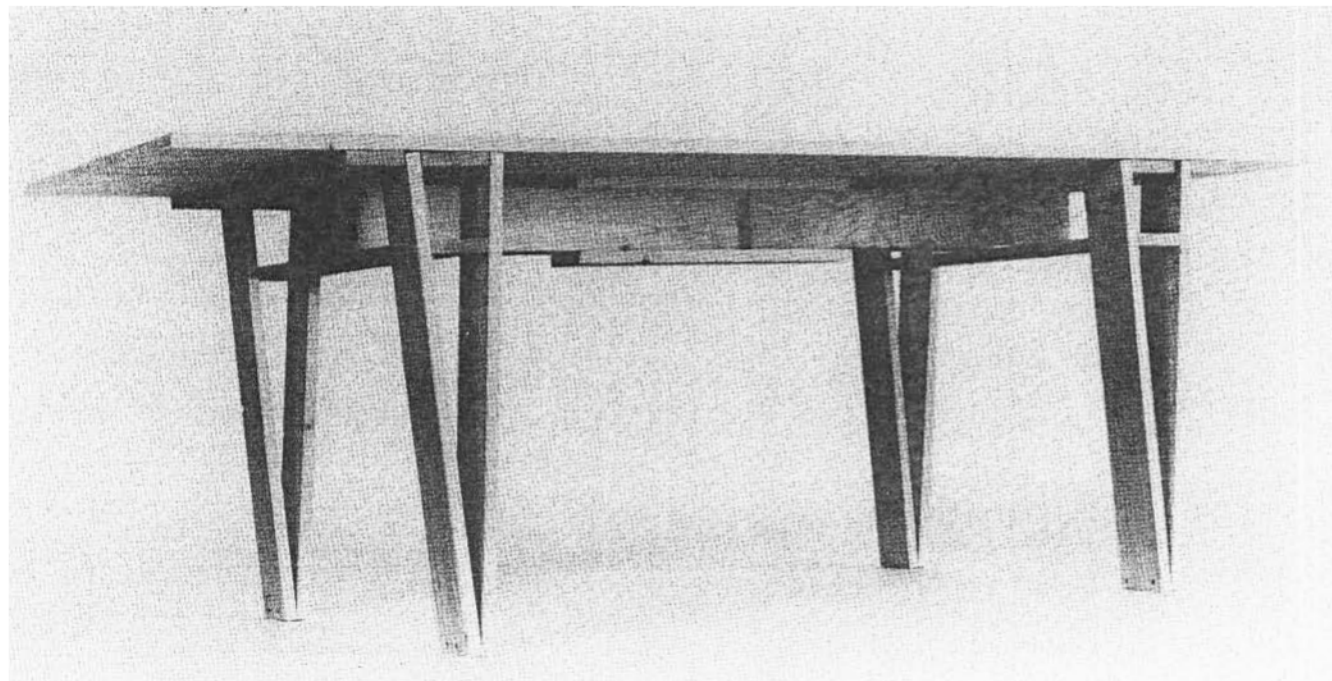


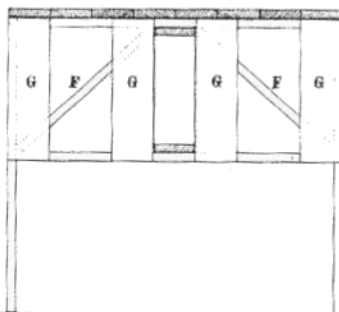
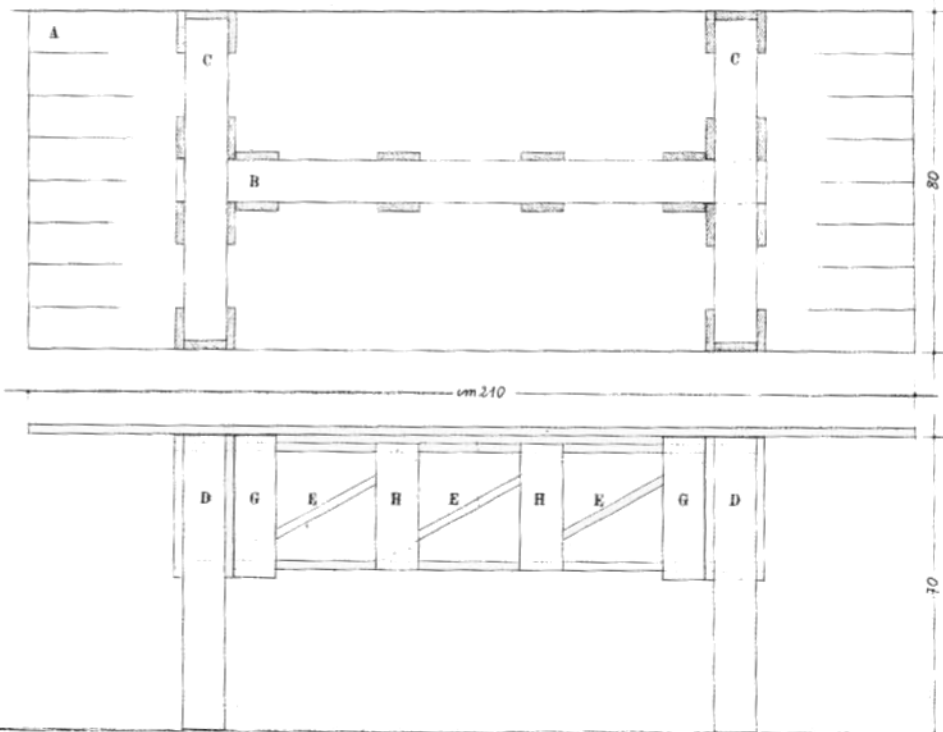
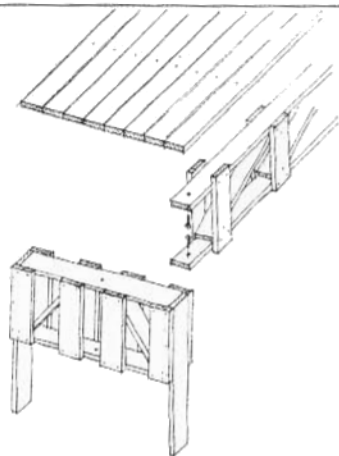
TAVOLETTE OCCORRENTI

SEZIONE	LARGHEZZA (MONTATA)	QUANTITÀ
A	2x10	200 8
B	"	130 1
C	"	80 2
D	"	70 8
E	"	58 2

SEZIONE	LARGHEZZA (MONTATA)	QUANTITÀ
F	2x10	50 2
G	2x8,5	80 2

1123 xD	SCALA 1:5	5/73
TAVOLO RETTANGOLARE		
ENZO MARI - PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 - 20123 MILANO - TELEFONO 4493961		



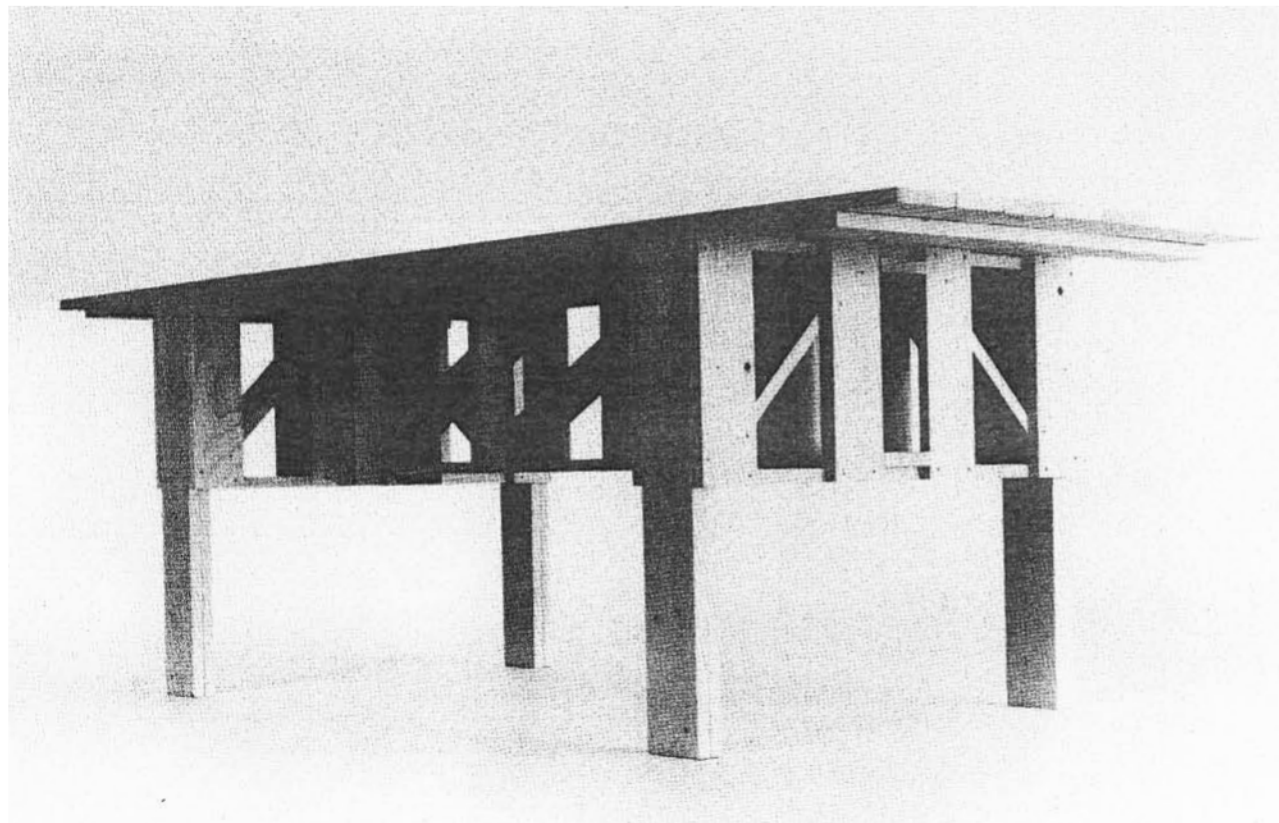


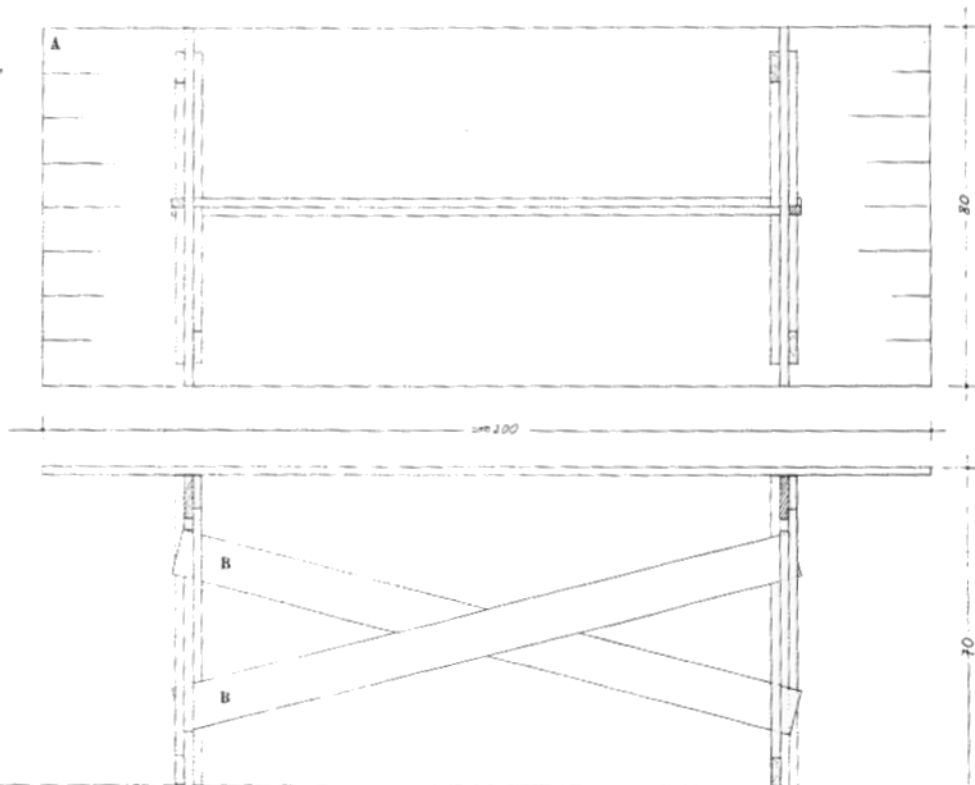
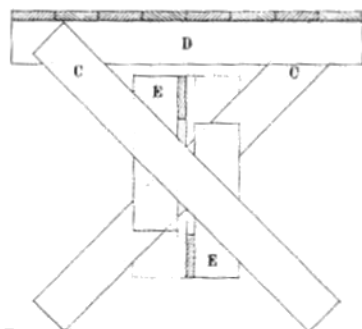
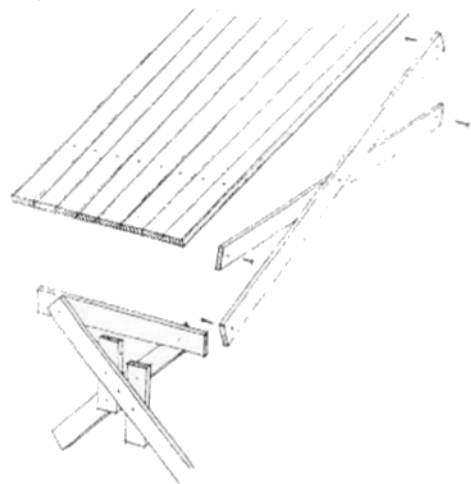
TAVOLETTE OCLORRENTI

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITA'
A	2x10	210
B	11	140
C	11	76
D	11	70
E	11	48

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITA'
F	2x10	42
G	11	34
H	11	30

1123 xC	SCALA 1:5	5/73
TAVOLO RETTANGOLARE		
ERZO MARI PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 20123 MILANO TELEFONO 4853551		

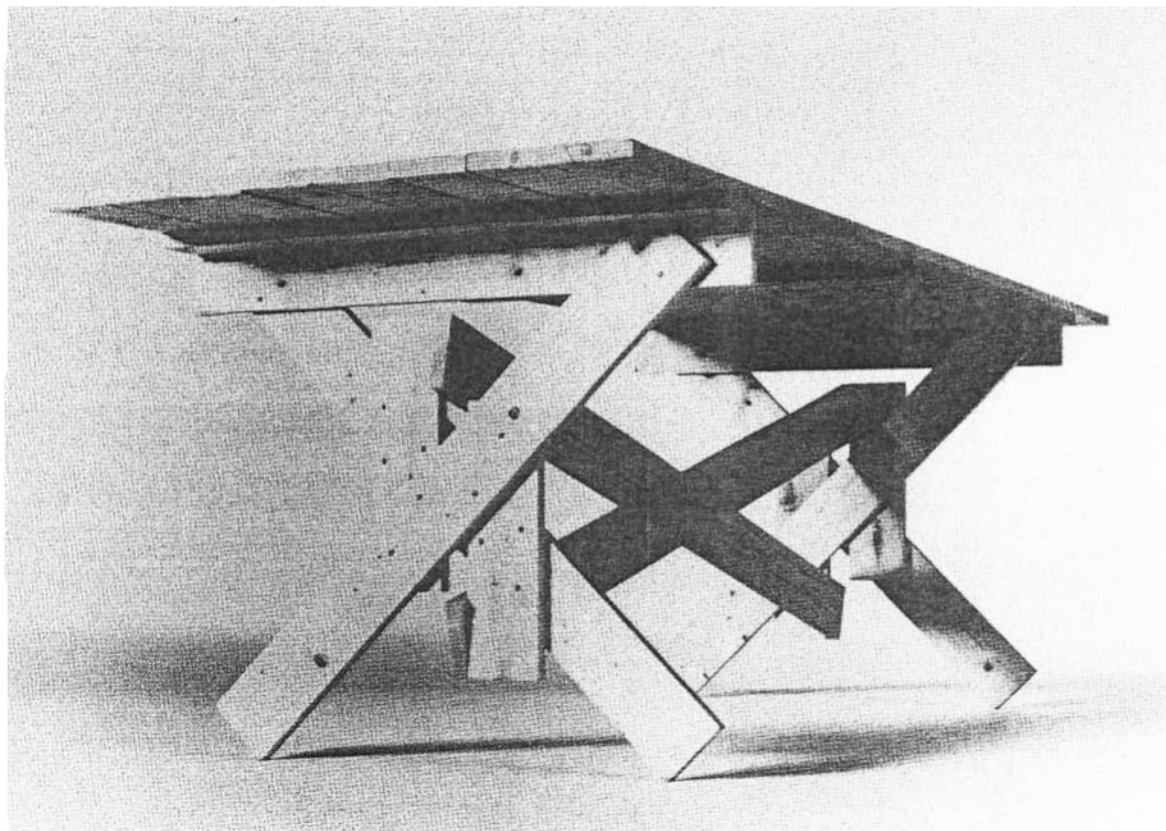


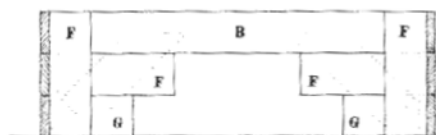
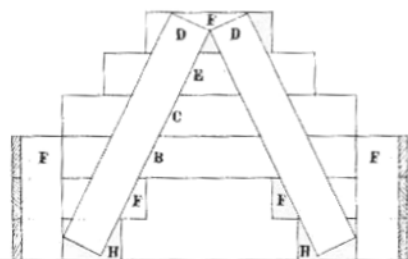
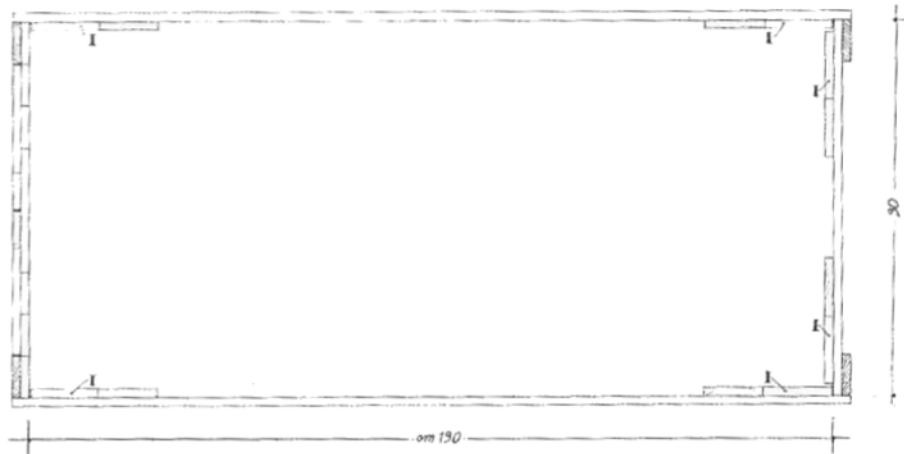
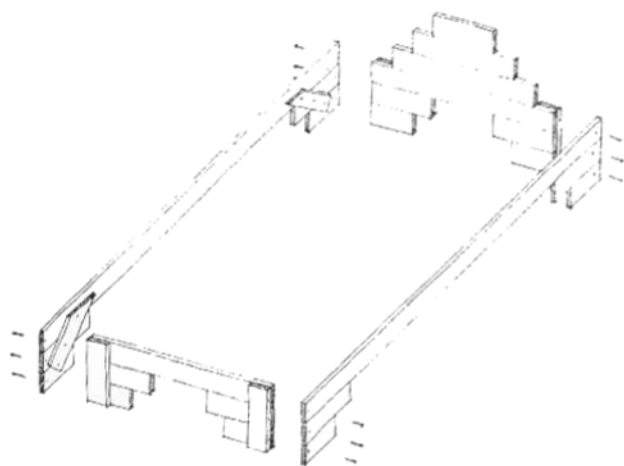


TAVOLETTE COLORANTI

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
A	2x10	200
B	11	164
C	11	89
D	11	80
E	11	35

1123 x E	SCALA 1:5	5/73
TAVOLO RETTANGOLARE		
RENZO MATTI - PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 - 20123 MILANO - TELEFONO 4951851		



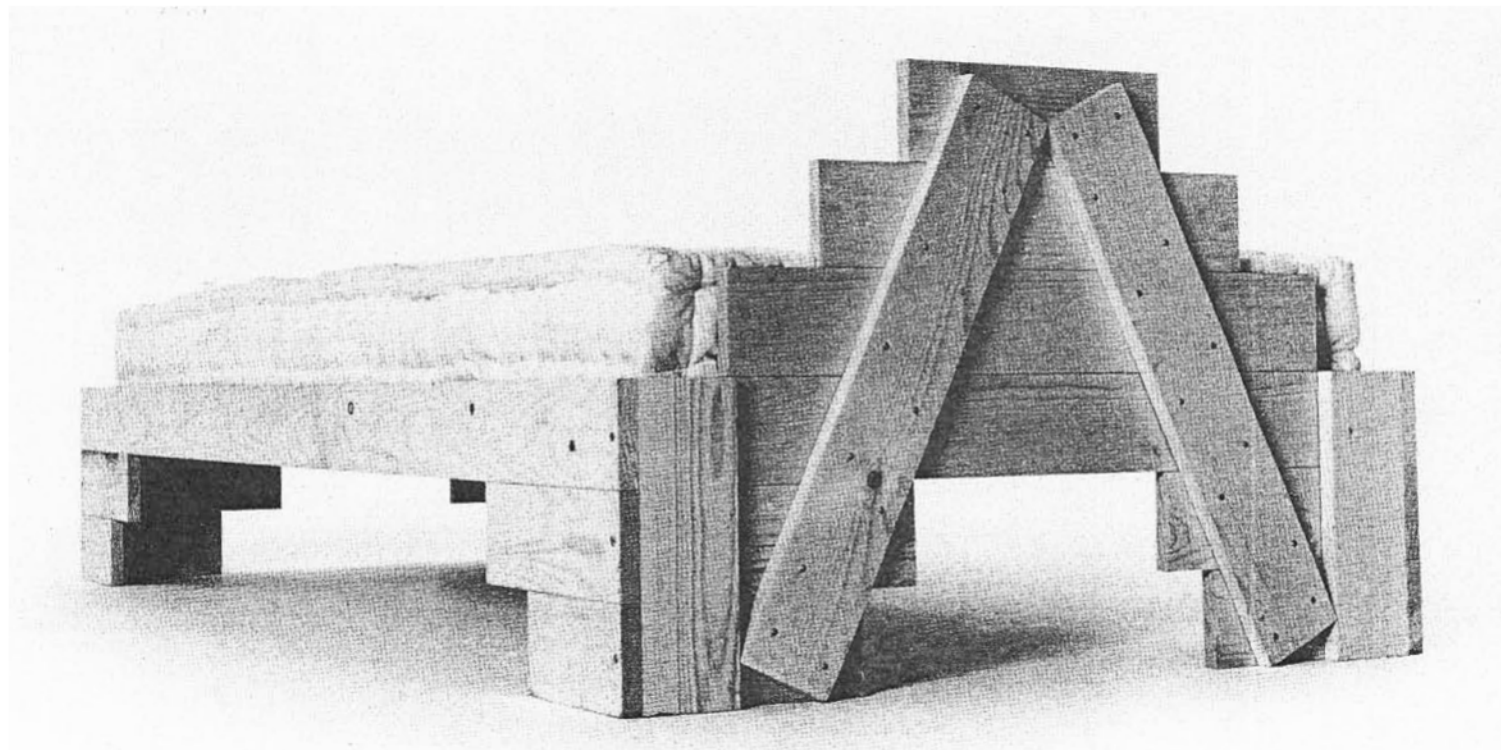


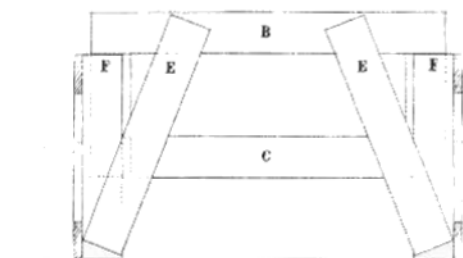
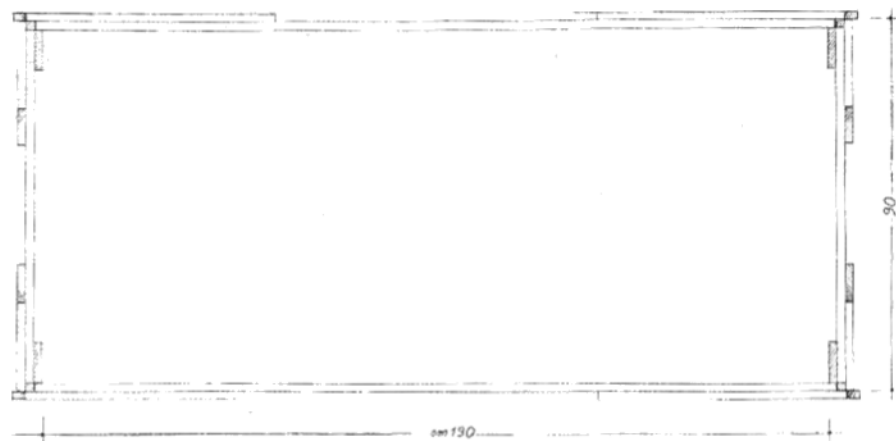
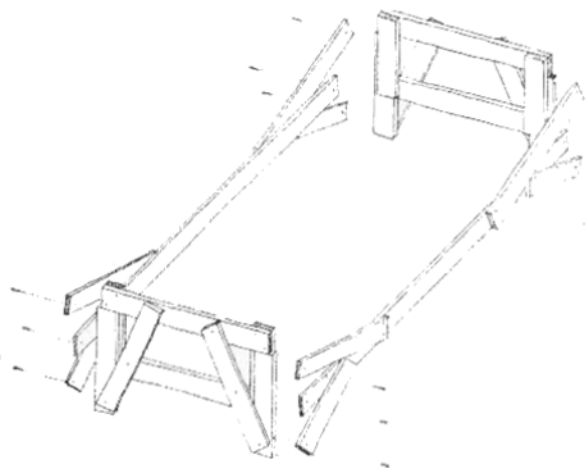
TAVOLETTE OCCORRENTI

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
A	2x10	198
B	"	30
C	"	70
D	"	60
E	"	50

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
F	2x10	30
G	"	20
H	"	36
I	"	32

1123 XM
 SCALA 1:5
 5/73
 LETTO
 ENZO MARI - PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 - 20123 MILANO - TELEFONO 452851



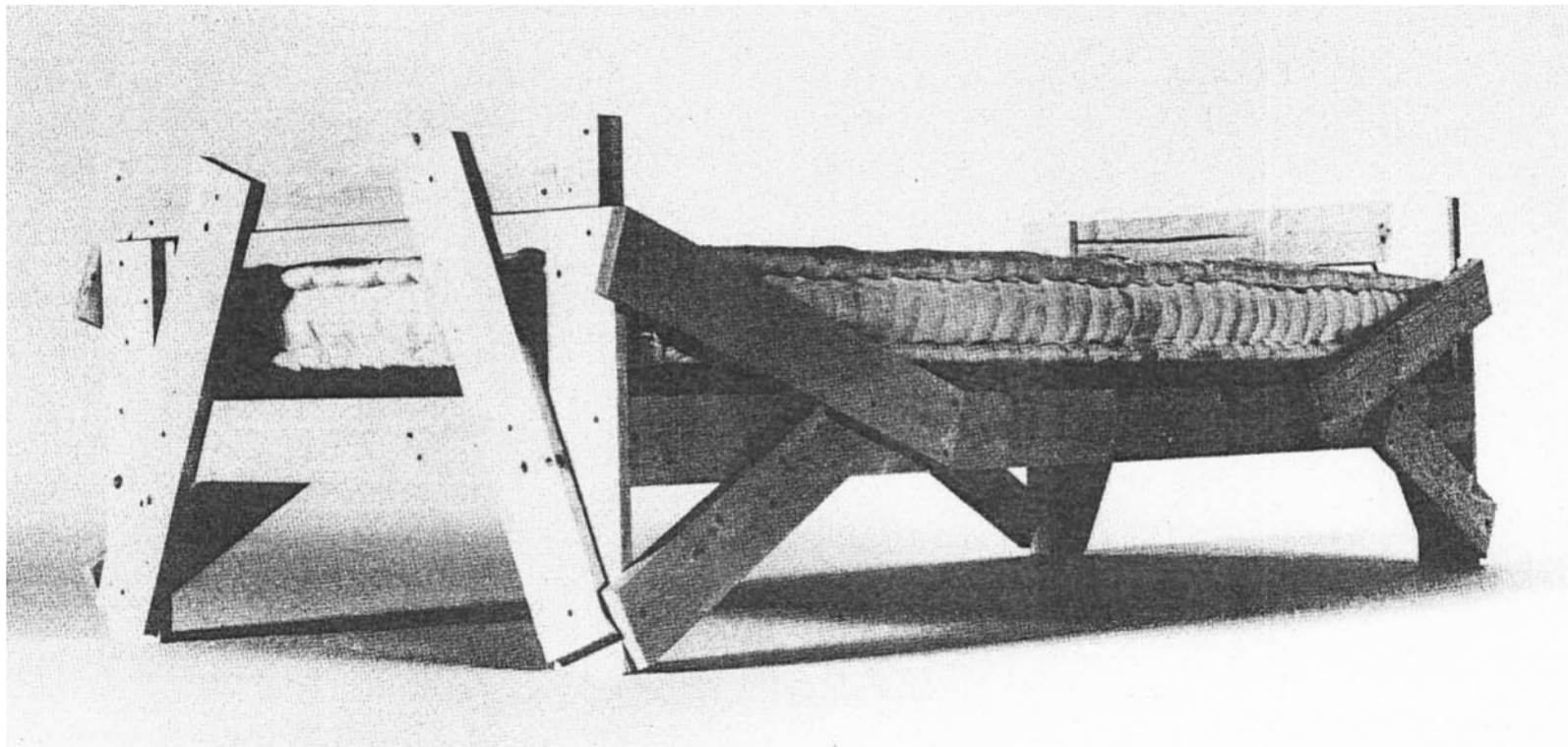


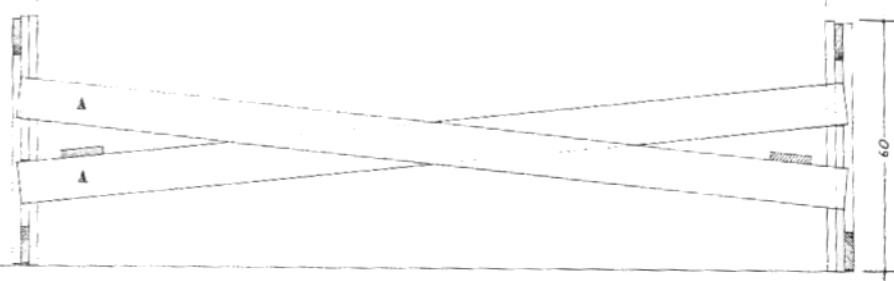
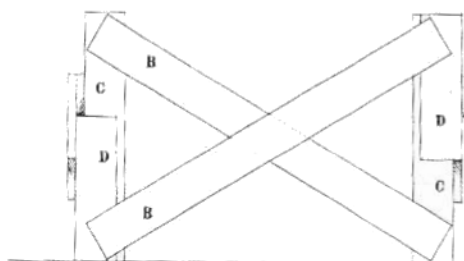
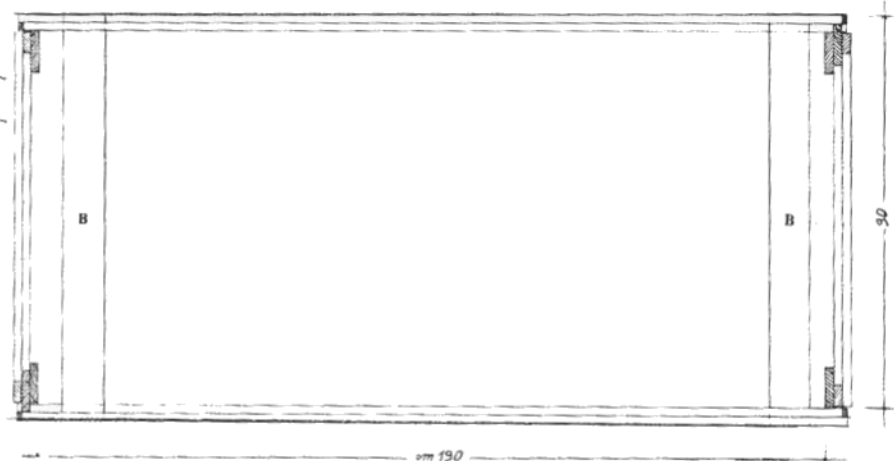
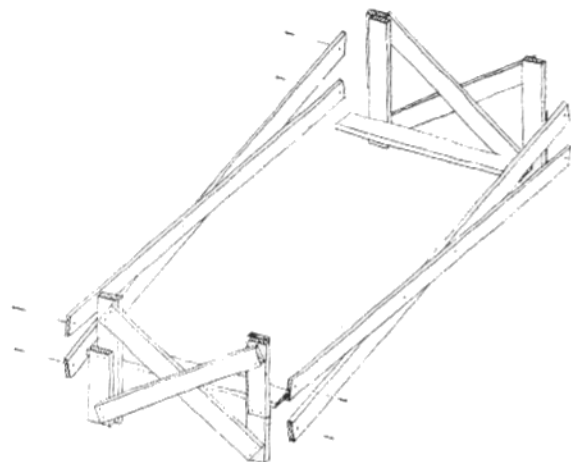
TAVOLE PER OCCORRENTI

	SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
A	2x10	136	2
B	11	86	2
C	11	10	2
D	11	63	4
E	11	59	4

	SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITÀ
F	2x10	90	4
G	11	60	8

1123 **XN** SCALA 1:5 5/73
LETTO
 ENTO MARZ. PINZALE BARACCA 10 20123 MILANO - TELEFONO 409095



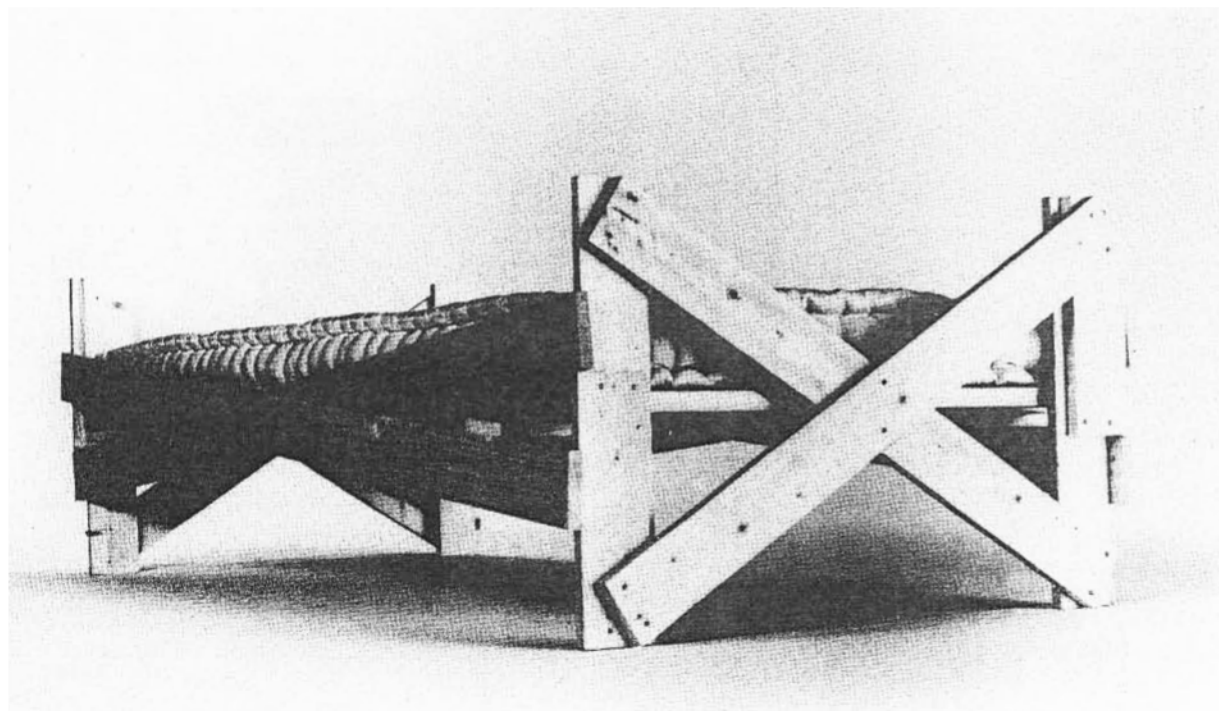


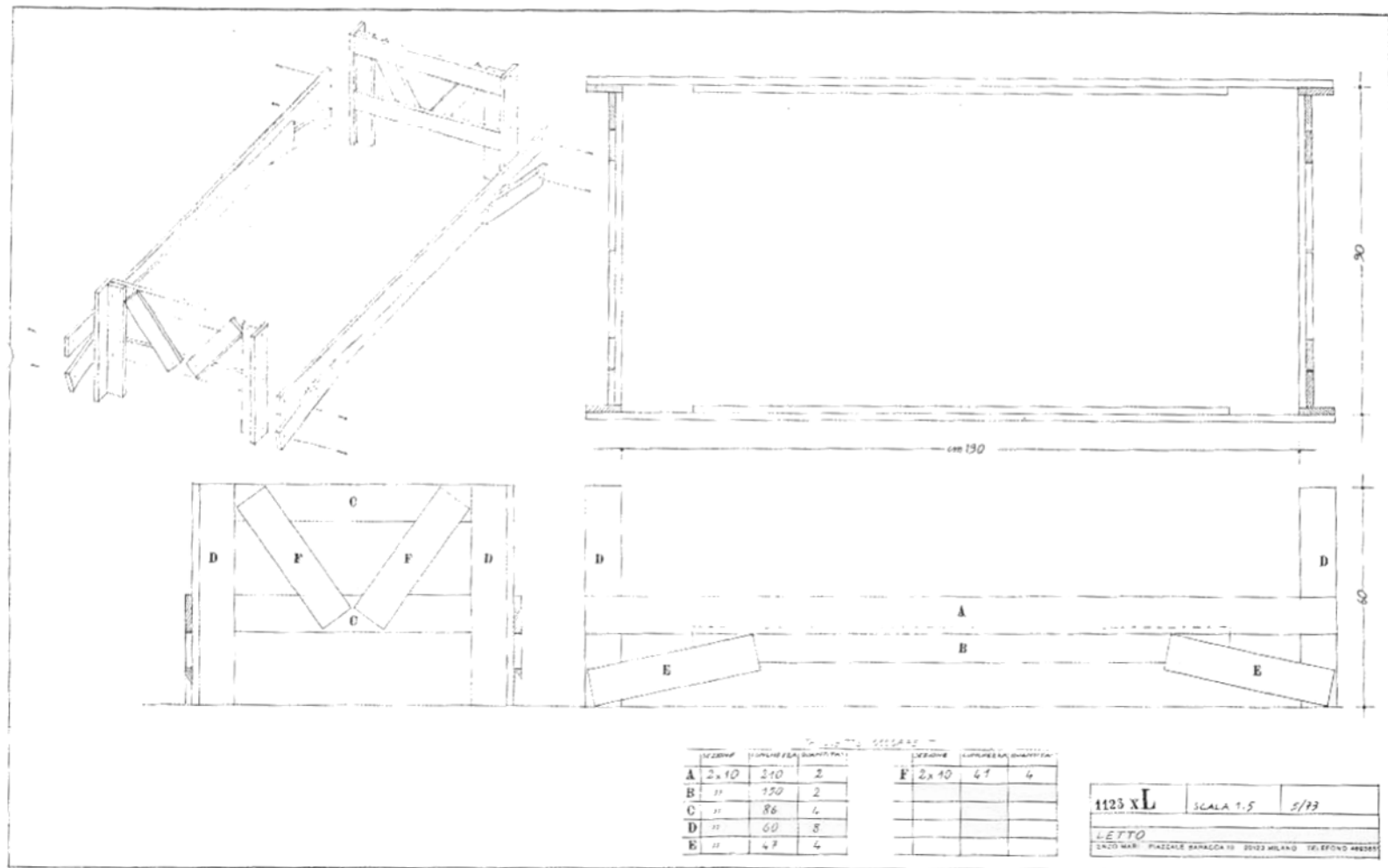
TAVOLETTE OCCORRENTI			
LENGHA	SPESORE	QUANTITA'	
A	2x10	200	4
B	"	98	6
C	"	60	4
D	"	35	4

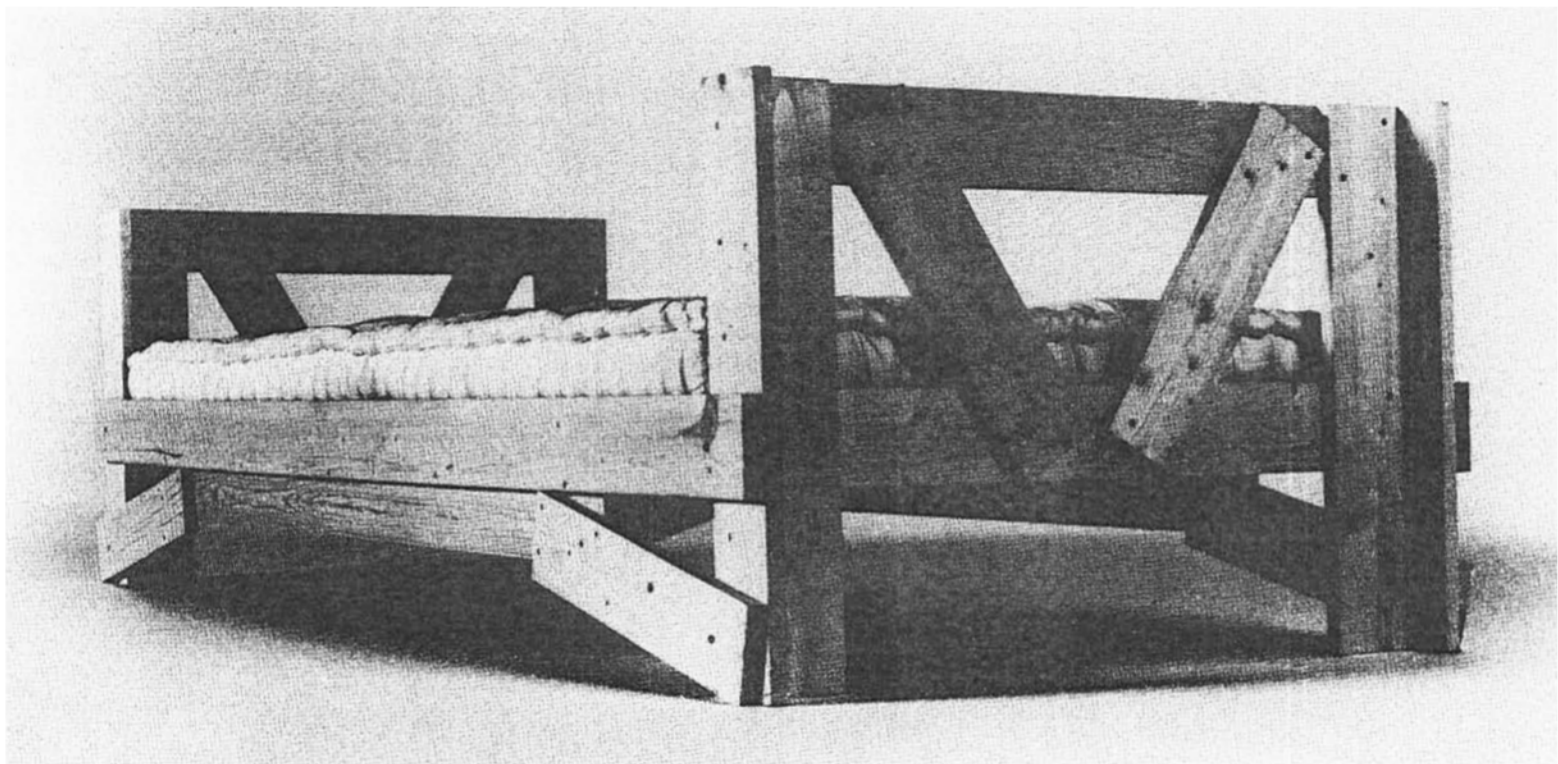
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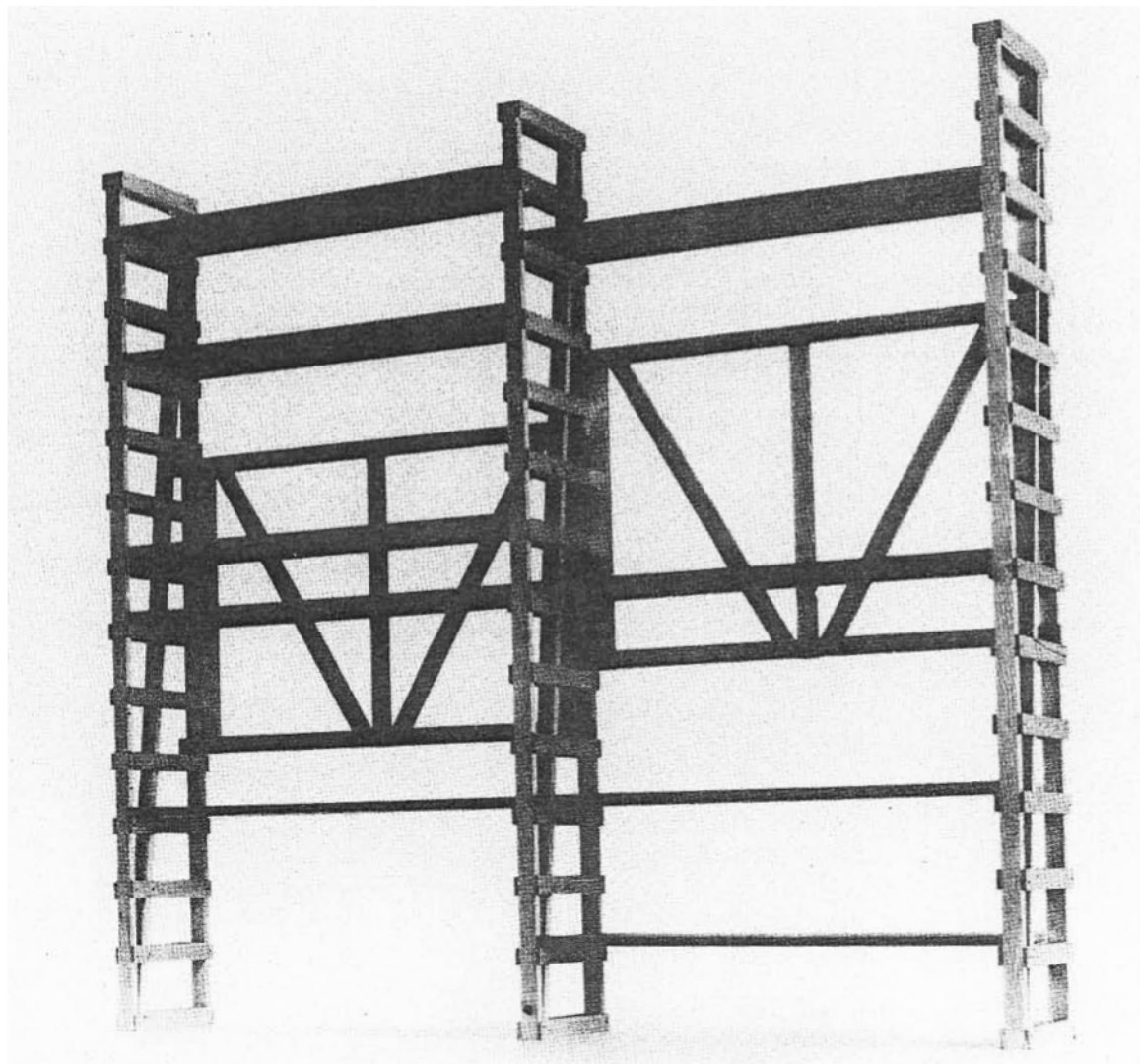
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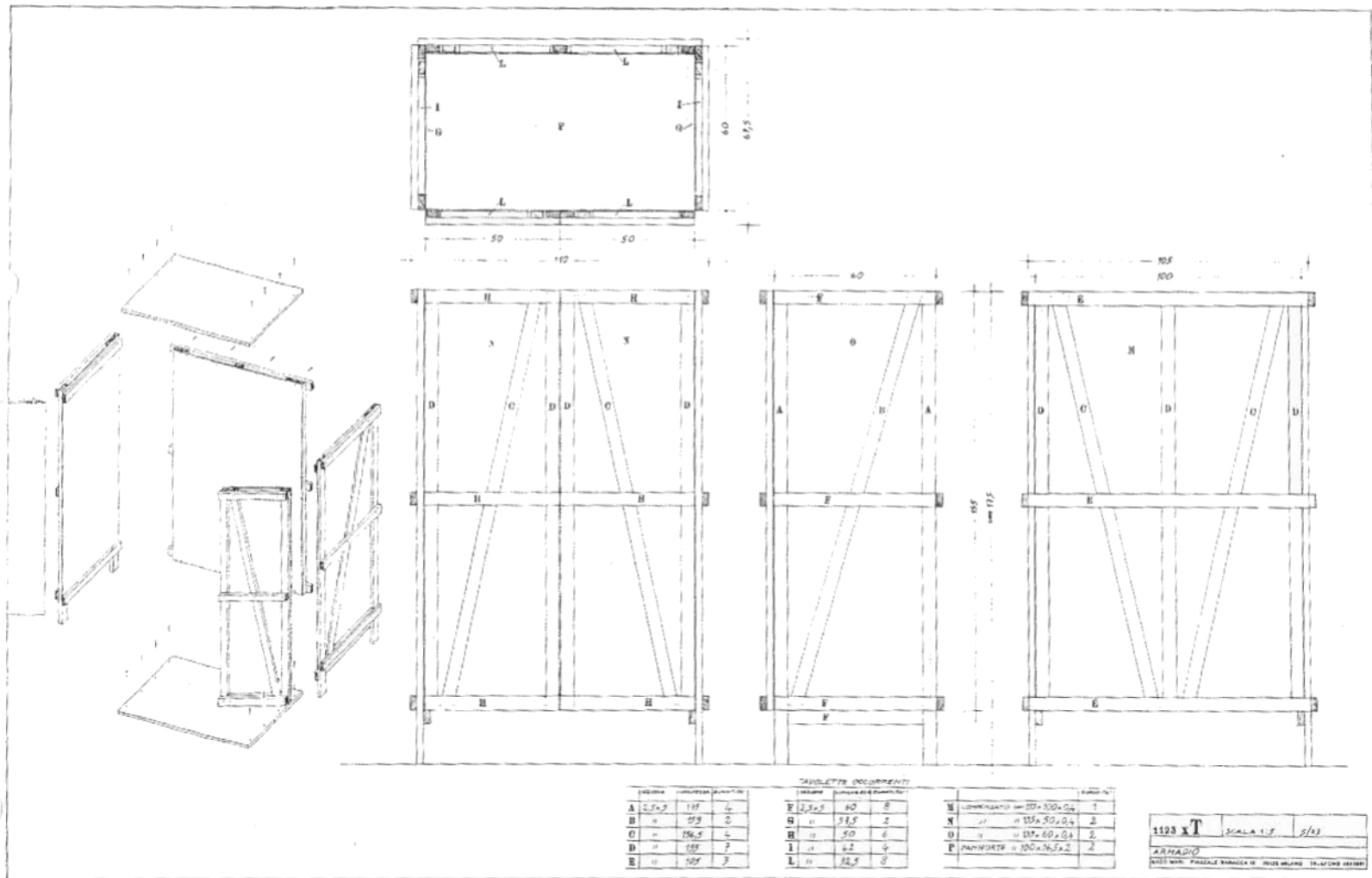
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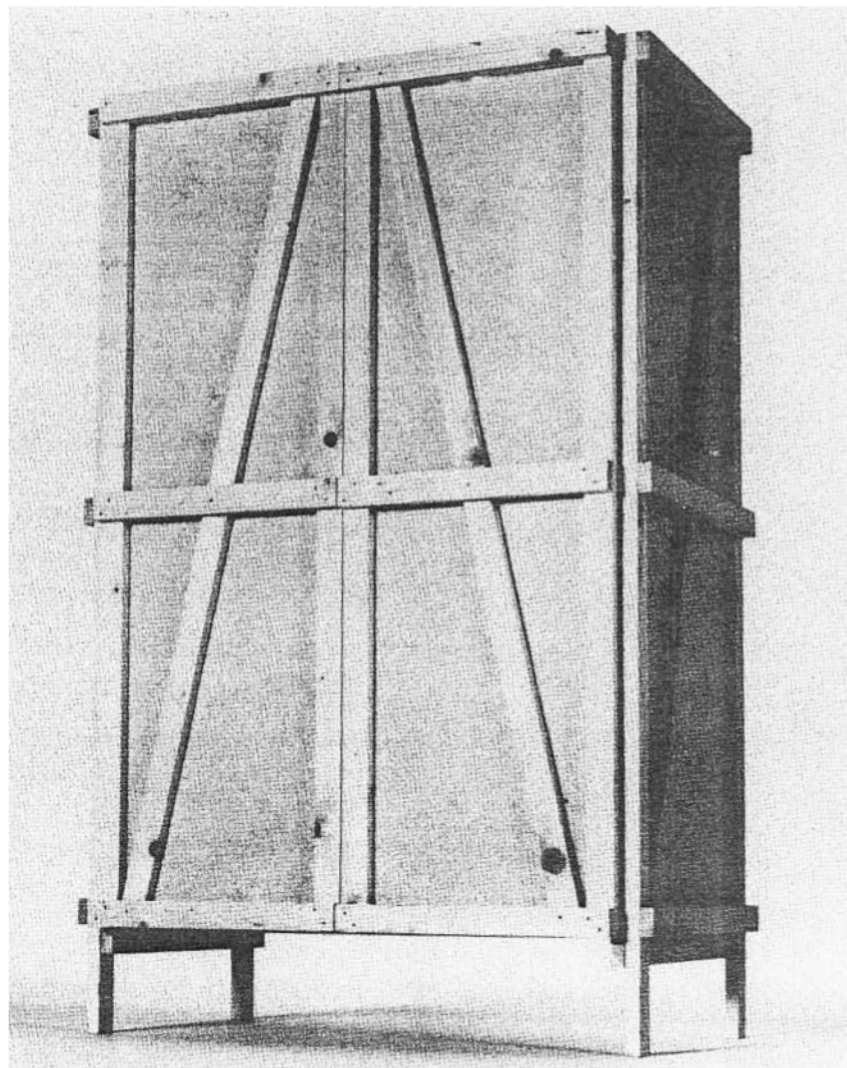












**NOTES, ARTICLES, INTERVIEWS AND
LETTERS CHOSEN FOR PUBLICATION IN
THE CATALOGUE FOR THE EXHIBITION
AVANGUARDIE E CULTURE POPOLARI AT
THE GALLERIA D'ARTE MODERNA IN
BOLOGNA, 1 MAY 1975.**

*Material from the discussion by myself
and others regarding the possibility of
freeing oneself from the social
conditioning present in one's
relationship with the environment.*

Introduction

[...]

In my job as designer, or rather as an intellectual who contradicts the actual state of things, I try within the network of commissions and projects to 'smuggle in' moments of research and ways of creating the stimulus to free oneself from ideological conditioning, standard norms, behaviour and taste. One of the operations carried out with this ambitious aim to influence social assumptions is on show at the present exhibition (and was initially published in a catalogue entitled: «Proposta per un'autoprogettazione», Galleria Milano, April 1974).

What happened as a result of this

initiative is the exact opposite to the initiative itself. Showing here the different and complex aspects of some of the responses (by critics, the public, use and valuation), in an attachment, I intend not to illustrate the project itself but to produce examples of the contradictions existing in social phenomena, on a trip through a specific social project and the different levels and ways of interpretation in separate and conditioned reality. (17-3-1975)

1) Public notice given by Enzo Mari (regarding his «Proposta per un'auto-progettazione»)

A project for making easy-to-assemble furniture using rough boards and nails. An elementary technique to teach anyone to look at present production with a critical eye.

(Anyone, apart from factories and traders, can use these designs to make them by themselves.

The author hopes the idea will last into the future and asks those who build the furniture, and in particular, variations of it, to send photos to his studio at 10 piazzale Baracca, 10 - 20123 Milan).

2) Newspaper comments on the operation and the reasons behind it (in an article by G. Manzini, in «Paese sera», 11 August 1974)

...In one or maximum two days' work, it is possible to furnish a whole apartment, bed, chairs, tables, wardrobe, bookcase, desk, and a bench too. Cost about 40 thousand lire per article if you use wooden planks that are already squared and smoothed; 20.000 lire, perhaps even less if you use rough wood that needs sawing and finishing. The proposal is by Milanese designer Enzo Mari, who offers a free catalogue with about twenty drawings showing how to build your own interior. ..Enzo Mari's "do-it-yourself" has the undertones of a challenge or provocation, at the very least it is intended as an encouragement to reflect critically on the objects that fill our daily existence.

...Mari gives two «versions» of his proposal: either get the rough planks and do it all by yourself, with the help of the catalogue the designer offers free of charge, or for 40.000 lire order the «pack of planks» from the Simon International factory in Bologna, which has supported the project and sells the material needed to make three pieces of furniture (the third option is to order some extremely complex designs from the factory, which cost 1,200 lire). Difficult? Not at all, says Mari: there's no need for

glue, no need for particular joints, the method is extremely simple and is the one used by carpenters to build their work benches and scaffolding, a semi-spontaneous method which is very easy to learn. There is no danger of getting it wrong therefore: a poorly shaped plank does not affect the stability of the bed or table. There's nothing odd about Enzo Mari's proposal. It may appear touched with ingenuousness, or even up to its neck in unrealistic ambitions. So what's this - from now on are we all going to start sawing tables and nailing planks together? Mari is the first to realise that this is a limit, perhaps an insurmountable contradiction: of course, he says, his «gesture» is undoubtedly utopian, it is undoubtedly overly ambitious, but what is a designer to do who so far has fought without success to propose to the industry objects and solid furniture at low cost and which could provide an alternative to the dominant «taste»? Should he throw away his drawing board and deny his role? Should he shut up, stop working? His giving up would be a double and irreparable defeat. The designer for all his unrealistic ambitions and perhaps impotence, needs instead to try to move within the narrow confines available to him, to take the only route open, i.e. that of the challenge, the provocation, appealing to the public directly for support...

3) *A Critical and Artistic Evaluation*
(G.C. Argan, in «L'Espresso», 5 May 1974)

...As regards us, with more explicit ideological and political commitment, Enzo Mari has turned his back on the illuminated entrepreneurs and is now proposing anti-industrial design. It harks back to a pre-artisan, pre-linguistic stage: to the primary stages of pottery with its organic gestural expressiveness of mixing and interlacing, and to the piece of furniture with rudimentary constructions of modular planks «assembled» and nailed together. It has social ends: to give away projects, executive drawings: «anybody, except factories and traders can use these designs to make them by themselves». It is not the «DIY» that the Americans preach about for their free time; by thinking with your own hands, by «making» your own thoughts you make them clearer, even if they concern, just as an example, the politics of Kissinger. Mari is not interested in the myth of the noble savage nor does he practise tribal cults; but perhaps he thinks, like Robinson on his island, that we live in the megalopolis of neo-capitalism. To survive he had to start making the tools with which to build himself a place to live in. Mari is right, everyone should have a project: after all it is the best way to avoid being designed yourself.

4) *Some typical letters, chosen from the thousands that we received at the studio, containing considerations or objectives that were totally different from the aim of the project.*

Your idea to revolutionise the world of distribution is undoubtedly to be admired. It is an idea shared by a wide section of the public sensitive to the question and not only those who, like me, fight for existence along with my stay-at-home wife and a rent of 70,000 lire a month.

Our first child will be born in a few months. I beg you, Milanese architect with your kind ways, to help me make an alternative crib (or cot), very simply and with very little cost and a lot of love. I would like to be able to have an engraved «D» at the bed-head because if its a boy I'm going to call it Davide and if its a girl Daniela...

V.M. (Portici, 22 July 1974)

...I would like to receive one of your illustrative catalogues not only for my own personal use, but also to see the possibilities, given the simplicity of the tools (hammer and nail), for physically handicapped youths to construct the furniture you propose. I am teacher in a Middle School for physically disabled children in Marina di Massa...

G.P. (Sarzana, 14 august 1974)

...I am sure you will think I am the

usual maniac interested in the question only because he can see the chance for a new hobby to fill his so-called «free time» (one of the many myths that our civilisation has created to make us think we are not being conditioned). You will find in me, I confess with reluctance, the typical, fully integrated employee who out of necessity sees initiatives of this type as his last chance, the one not to be missed. My house is decorated according to all the tenets that an opulent society demands, but at the same time not entirely subjected to prevailing taste.

What I'm saying is that if I manage to make a piece of furniture, even if it's only a chair (which apart from anything else I like the design of), I will use it; it won't be a mere knickknack for the home, a sort of chinoiserie that serves to add a touch of originality to show to your friends, it will just be a piece of furniture that is an end to itself for once, i.e. to sit on, for eating, sleeping and for this alone...

L.P. (Florence, 6 September 1974)

5) *Advanced entrepreneurial use (press release by D. Gavina for «Simon International» after their interest in the «Proposta»)*

Dear Mari,

For a long time I have been thinking that if I were a sculptor I would like to hold an exhibition of prodigious and

essential objects, with such a simple structure that anyone following the instructions could make them at home for themselves.

As part of the operation Ultramobile, with Matta's «Margarita» I intended to give everyone a diagram showing how to re-use a sheet metal bin by turning it into a chair. You can therefore imagine my satisfaction when I realised that your ideas fitted perfectly with our plans. The furniture you propose, with its elementary design and made with simple planks and nails belongs to a new concept we wish to address.

...Metamobile is looking for another direction, starting from scratch, but which encompasses the vivid knowledge and experience of the recent revolutionary past.

Let's meet soon.

6) *Questions initially asked in the presentation of the «Proposta» (by V. Vercelloni, in the catalogue itself). 1974*

The significance of your proposal implicitly overcomes all moral restrictions: both the banal anti-consumer one and that of a return by the bourgeoisie to these objects for a self-critical and iconoclastic consumption of their traditional consumer symbols (perhaps through the young groups of the liveliest members of the middle classes). That this operation is not, moreover, the answer to the furnishing problems of the working classes (in Italy today) is obvious even in your awareness of the possibilities or lack of them of an «alternative culture» and of the objective impotence of a “progressive” technician or intellectual in today’s society. But here it could be stressed that this operation itself has certain objective values: first of all that of being able to become a new «instrument» (and as such usable by anyone in any way) in the world of the home, and that it is strongly connected to «enlightened» values (debunkers when compared to traditional values; anti-consumerist, rejecting a society that wastes and embraces the useless; that tend to focus attention once again on man and his life rather than the object and its conscious and unconscious values;

democratic because they operate within the general vector of self-management). Do you agree with this interpretation? ...Talking about it together we found parallels with past events and different productions, in the advanced technology/mass consumption ratio. The obviously non-mechanical example is that of the American balloon-frame construction system (a mass of standardised wooden planks thanks to which in the 19th century entire cities, pioneer wagons and boats were built). The main characteristic about the balloon-frame system was the apparent ignorance (or conscious rejection) of more advanced technology (trusses, also made of wood, beams and tie-beams etc.); this alternative was clearly available to anyone (the person directly involved, the common employee, took the place of the skilled site worker). Therefore what seemed to be a step backwards in the technology sector turned into a quantitative/qualitative extension of production and habits. Do you think your proposal contains something similar (in particular when you think of the «furniture in pieces» on sale in the department stores and ironmonger’s rather than the present «boutiques», so loudly acclaimed by the working press)?

7) *A original letter from a student who asks for the instructions for carrying out other (and all) the author’s designs for himself.*

...I am writing to you today to tell you that with your furniture I have completely furnished my room and that of my brother. I am a student in my last year of Civil Engineering, my brother is in his 4th year at secondary school. You can imagine how much we like your furniture. We have made: 2 drawing tables (1123 XG), 4 chairs (1123 XR), 2 bookcases covering the entire wall, 1 table (1123 XF). I am now making: 2 wardrobes, 1 bed 1123 XM, 1 bed 1123 XL. We have not modified your projects in any way apart from assembling the tables with bronzed wooden round-headed screws. Neither did we have any problems during construction except with the chairs, which came out perfectly all the same (we were forced to use wooden dowels as well as screws). We gave all the tables, made of white pine, cut to measure and planed on all sides by our carpenter, two coats of boiled linseed oil. The cost of the carpenter was 265 thousand lire including the plywood for the wardrobes and the two surfaces of the drawing boards (3.5 cm. veneered wood, lamina or multiply plywood were too expensive). We are not sending you the photos of

each piece yet, but we will send you those of the two rooms we have finished. In issue no. 443 of «Panorama» (which takes a great interest in your artistic production) in the well-known column on the penultimate page I found more of your furniture, the Frate B table in iron and crystal glass, and a chair made with iron rods produced by Driade of Milan.

Would it be too much if I asked for the designs or technical data of these? You see for the «chair with a zip», another of your designs, published in number 451, it was easy from the photos to understand how it was made and the measurements as well (we modernised our kitchen chairs with these). For the above pieces it would be rather more difficult without taking measures that would be costly.

Thanking you in advance, I would like to take the opportunity of wishing you a Happy New Year full of new ideas.
P.C. (Bari, 1 January 1975)

*8) A critical-ideological debate
between E. Mari and E. Facchinelli
(in «L'erba voglio», issue no.16)*

E.F. When we saw the drawings for your furniture for the first time we thought it was necessary to go through someone who would cut out and prepare the wood that was needed. Instead we have seen that there's no need for an intermediary. All you really need is the catalogue.

E.M. In fact I tried to reduce the technical difficulties to a minimum. I could hardly ask people to start straight from the tree. For centuries the sawmills have been delivering wood cut to standard sizes, like bricks from the furnaces, if it comes to that. So I thought of these boards prefabricated in different sections which could very easily be shortened to the length required. The system is not only made simple by the use of the nail but also by the simplified cut of the saw. There are no diagonal or complex cuts, or anything needing joints. What's more, the simple orthogonal cuts don't even need to be well done. Even if the struts are a bit uneven, as you pointed out to me, everything works all the same. It is in this sense that the project entails the direct use of the prefab board; and thus, apart from a few exceptions, each of the objects is made using a single board section. This means you can buy the boards from the sawmills or specialist stores in lengths (the most common format is four metres). Then, given the simplicity of the cuts you can also ask for them to be cut to measure for very little extra charge.

E.F. It is interesting though that when we look at your drawings everyone thinks that there has to be a kind of intermediary factory that will supply the ready-cut pieces. If this factory isn't available we think we can't go

on, that the project can't be carried through etc.. In short, probably the greatest difficulty in making these projects popular is ideological, there is a form of prejudice firmly rooted in the division of work and tasks, which is felt as incapacity or impossibility to do certain things.

E.M. This is certainly an important factor, in fact it touches on one of the reasons for this operation. One tends usually to give specialist roles that are not ours a particular position, one says: this requires a technology, a culture, a special approach that precludes me. And this is an ideological approach, because if it is true that certain technical difficulties exist and specific technical experience is required, what should be stressed is that the art of design (and here I'm not only talking about my own sector) is simple and easy. It seems or is difficult for different, unrelated reasons, one of the first of which is that the space for the substance of a project is almost never allowed, only that for its appearance.

E.F. Another thing. It seems to us that these things you have designed stand, as objects, in contradiction to all the other objects already existing, a table like this certainly becomes dominant, causing that other table to have an identity crisis, or certain types of

things designed and built according to industrial models, it tends to expel these immediately. Do you think this is a significant fact?

E.M. These objects don't seem false to me, they aren't mystified. But why aren't they? They are made using the same methods as carpenters for their work benches and their scaffolding, just as they are by stage-set workers, it is a semi-spontaneous technique... the fact is though that this table stands properly, all the details announce their functions. This leg is a leg, this latticework underneath is a strengthening beam, the small strut under the boards of the table top are there to stop it vibrating, the nail serves to link the boards together. Having reduced the technique down to its reasons, to its simplest moments, this is what makes this object autonomous.

E.F. But who will accept this table? Not many people evidently, if the majority go with the ideology of the objects you want to demystify and if the furniture industry is already largely an ideological industry, or rather an industry that sells objects loaded with imagery, which have value because of the imagery they are loaded with, and of which the high price is one of the fundamental factors. Only those who already live within a different framework will be able to accept it,

those who have an idea of another space in which to live and function.

E.M. People already aware of this world, who look at magazines... will probably accept it. Others... in my experience with the manual workers or the carpenters themselves who made these models, these people know how to appreciate the object as it is, but at the same time tend to be frightened of actually using it, because actually using it implies a relationship with others, fear of being judged... it is too unusual as an object. When you underline the economics of the table, i.e. its low cost, then rejection becomes even more direct, more immediate.

If this is the table that costs less than all the others then people are afraid of having to have something poor. When thinking of the home there is always an expectancy of a certain status which works on several levels... Then there are the young, the students, a few old ex young students...

E.F. On the other hand, there is undoubtedly a search for something in these objects that can be built using the simple methods you spoke about.

E.M. But this search was not so much a particular moment of mine. It was due more to the fact that I recognised myself in those models I mentioned before, the job of the carpenter... in the recovery of the essentiality of the job. It is an idea I have already expressed, it is something that manual workers already have, at certain times, at least those that do not have a direct relationship with the official culture. They already independently handle something they don't know how to recognise as their own precisely because they are conditioned by other models.

E.F. In what way is this work of yours different from the American do it yourself?

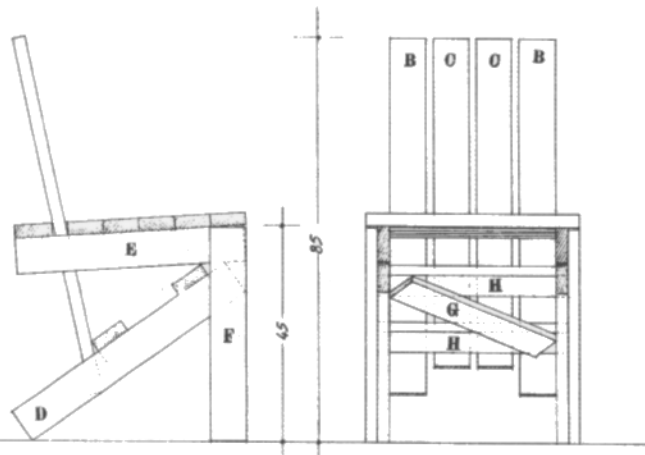
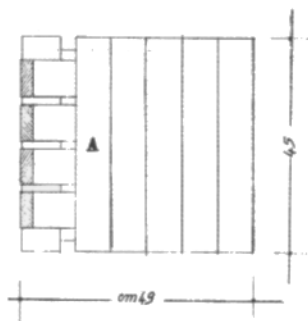
E.M. My intention was for it to be exactly the opposite. Then maybe it will return, or perhaps it is nothing

other than a part of the American model. Hobbies are nothing more than a degrading of culture, I mean doing something imitative, without knowing properly what you are doing, just to be able to say: I made it, just as a pastime. Within every specific field a search is made which can be experienced only by direct contact. It would in any case be wrong to think of a return to Arcadia, to a world where everyone does everything... industry exists and that's a positive thing, industry should be kept busy, be managed, made its own, tools should not be rejected... these items are not intended as alternatives to industrial ones, their creation is intended as a sort of critical exercise on design, and this is the reason why this experiment was called home design, not home production. The user, in repeating the operation, which can never be a slavish repetition... the designs have no measurements and while you are making them you can make changes, variations... when making the object the user becomes aware of the structural reasoning behind the object itself, therefore, subsequently he improves his own ability to assess the objects on the market with a more critical eye. You have already said that an object of this kind tends to expel the other objects from the room: this was precisely the type of assessment I wanted to reach. The fact that it is a critical work carried out

on a simple table rather than on other questions that appear more important or are more important, does not seem to me to be an important objection; what is important is the operation and the habit of the operation. And it is not irrelevant that the operation starts not from the general, but from a specific situation and that one acquires experimentally what is the specialist's prerogative. In this sense it is right to speak of manual ability, in the sense of direct experience, first hand experience, not in the tactile sense of working on a natural material such as wood. It is a search and searching can only be done through direct experience.

E.F. In this sense, have you thought of the possibility of doing this in schools, for example, where this way of learning critically through direct use of the materials, this direct appropriation of knowledge, doesn't exist?

E.M. In general terms, yes. But to be more specific, I don't know whether kids from Middle School are interested in this sort of object... at 13 or 14 I certainly wasn't thinking about tables! The operation could be proposed only within the field of objects that interest young people directly, otherwise it is just another way of stopping them from finding things out.

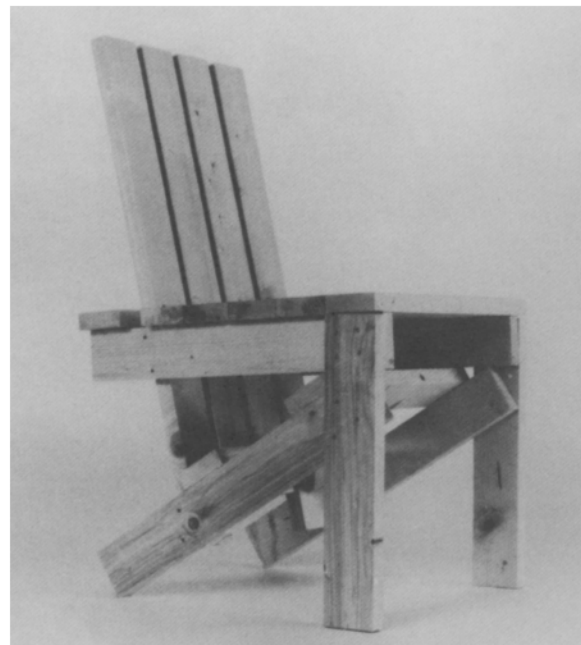


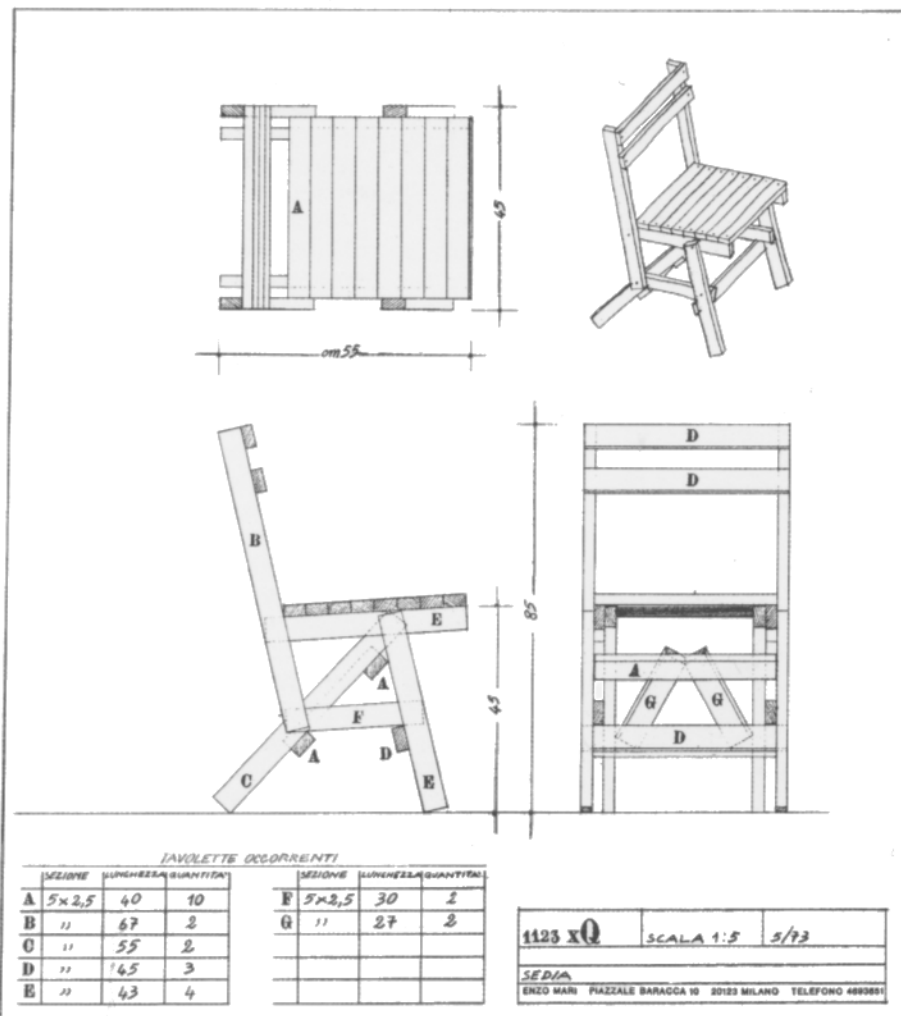
TAVOLETTE OCCORRENTI:

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITA'
A	7,5x2,5	45
B	"	76
O	"	70
D	"	54
E	"	48

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITA'
F	7,5x2,5	44
G	"	42
H	"	40

1123 x R	SCALA 1:5	5/73
SEDIA		
ENZO MARI PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 20123 MILANO TELEFONO 4090601		





COMMENT BY ENZO MARI ON THE
"PROPOSTA PER UN'AUTOPROGETTAZIONE"
TRANSCRIBED BY ARTURO CARLO
QUINTAVALLE IN THE BOOK "ENZO MARI"
PUBLISHED BY THE CENTRO STUDI E
ARCHIVIO DELLA COMUNICAZIONE AT THE
UNIVERSITY OF PARMA, 1983

After the production of the Day-night Sofa and other similar attempts I am in a state of terrible depression because I have come into contact first hand with the ingenuity of the approach to the well-designed object at low cost; the outcome is a complete failure and the public to whom these items are directed rejects them because they do not see them as belonging to the cultural system. When I say the public I'm also referring to young students or militant workers as well as to the political managers of the groups of the new Left, i.e. to that part of the public that clearly develops research and criticism, albeit limited to the basics of structural relationships. How is it possible to change the state of things? This is what I ask myself. How is it possible to accomplish the de-conditioning of form as a value rather than as strictly corresponding to content? The only way I know of, in that it belongs to my field of

experience, is what becomes possible when critical thought is based on practical work. Therefore the way should be to involve the user of a consumer item in the design and realisation of the item designed. Only by actually touching the diverse contradictions of the job is it possible to start to be free from such deeply rooted conditioning. But how is it possible to expect such an effort when the production tools are lacking as is, above all, the technical know-how, the technical culture it would take a fairly long time to acquire? On the other hand, if this were possible, anyone needing a table for example could learn what is essential to make a table, for example that the legs need to be planted firmly on the floor, therefore at the moment of purchase could evaluate within the vast array of objects on sale the models that corresponded most closely to their technical requirements and which are the best crafted, without entering into the merits of style or taste. As far as production tools are concerned what was important was to choose ones that were not so much easy to acquire but that were already commonly owned; almost everyone has a hammer and almost everyone has tried planting a few nails at some time. As regards material, the easiest to acquire is undoubtedly still the wooden plank. As regards technical culture, on the other hand, this is not so simple

but there is an example of technical culture theoretically open to everyone even though it is used only by manual workers. The technique of the carpenter and not, I want to stress, that of the cabinet maker; it is reduced to the minimum and in fact is never taught. It involves frames, wooden boards, or whatever, based on very simple principles which in actual fact lie behind the basic elements of engineering and architecture. The beam and the pilaster. The joining of the beam to the pilaster takes place using nails and because nailing is a kind of joint that does not guarantee steadiness, it is necessary to strengthen the joint using a nailed diagonal element. What emerges is a construction based on the triangle, which again is one of the fundamentals of engineering: the triangle cannot be deformed. Furthermore, because the economics of the carpenter's job force him to completely recoup the material used for a certain construction, he soon gets accustomed to using diagonal strengthening parts with a minimum of waste. As I said, the technique is easily acquired precisely because, once you have nailed a beam between a couple of pilasters, you add some transversal pieces to make the structure sturdy. Starting from these two choices, tools and technique, I and my young assistants tried making a series of objects, tables, benches, chairs and beds using this method in the sense

that the objects were not drawn beforehand but, by putting together a number of small planks we gave shape to the objects themselves, juxtaposing the minimum of planks necessary. What's more we did not concern ourselves with the perfection of the outcome because the only terms of judgement for all the models made was their solidity rather than the savings on the materials used, and even less did we worry about the painstaking work of formal ratios. These models were collected together in a small copybook and this was distributed in various ways, the final one being to send it free to anyone who asked for it.

The proposal was for people to be stimulated by the examples shown to make what they needed, including types that were not in the book and to make them freely, taking the example proposed simply as a stimulus, not as a model to copy. Our idea was a great success and I received thousands of requests. The book had to be reprinted. But once again the work theory fails because 99 % of the time the proposal is not understood or is understood differently. Obviously the proposal was only intended as a practical critical exercise. Obviously objects have to be produced using machinery and the most advanced technology and only in this way is it possible to have items that are good quality and economical. Machinery in theory frees man's work and Socialism itself is born and can

exist because industrial machinery exists. Obviously the models proposed were totally uneconomical from this point of view: any table, to give an example, correctly made by machine, requires no more than 30% of the material used in our models, with results that are far more stable and long lasting. Obviously it is important to socialise the implications of modern technology and this has to be done by really using technology to its utter best and not proposing the use of an archaic technology. Obviously wood should be used only where it is more economical than other materials.

Moreover, the use of wood should not be a way of re-proposing a material of ancient tradition instead of modern materials such as plastic, better suited to real production standards. In fact from this point of view all proposals using a natural material such as wood tend to be reactionary.

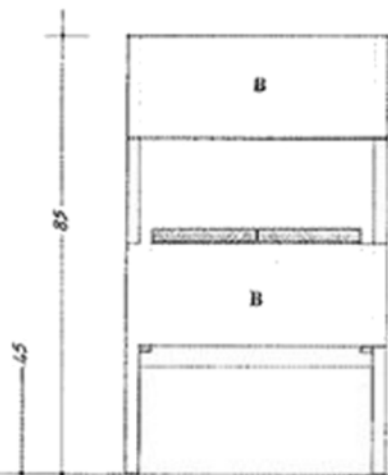
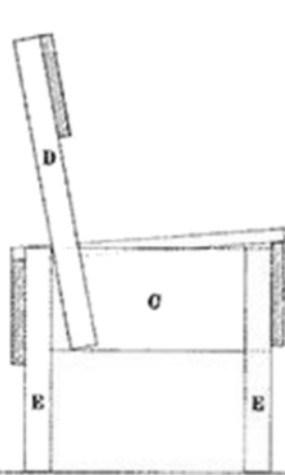
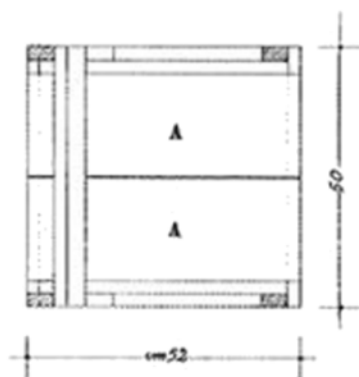
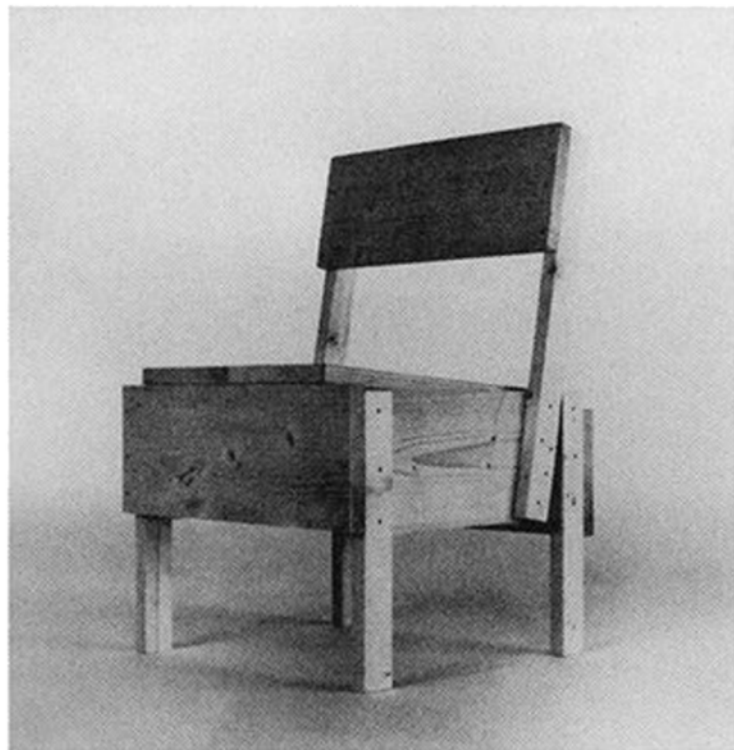
I was aware of these things and I tried to say them: it was simply a fact of using this material and this technique because it was the only way possible of carrying out the exercise. I was accused of trying to return to nature, of a drastic dislike of machinery, in the sense that I was accused of confusing the current production ratios of the machine rather than the positive potential of the machine itself.

Another objection was that in a sense I was encouraging the concept of the hobby and do-it-yourself, but clearly

the hobby phenomenon is always restrictive. It is always a petit bourgeois metaphor for the acquisition of technical culture.

Indeed most people who requested the copybook did so to:

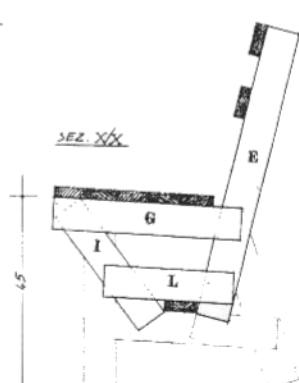
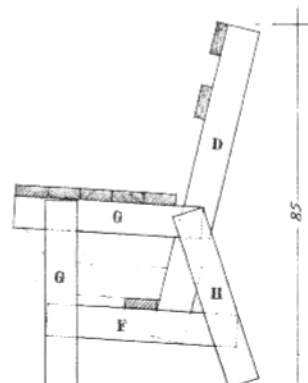
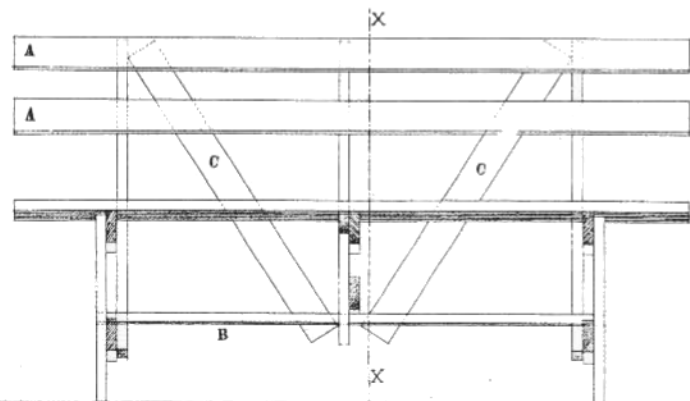
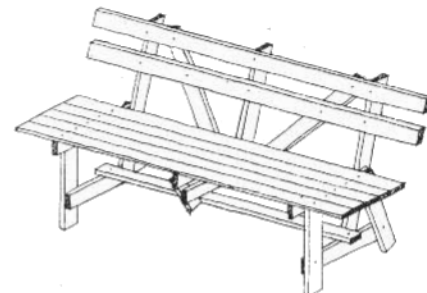
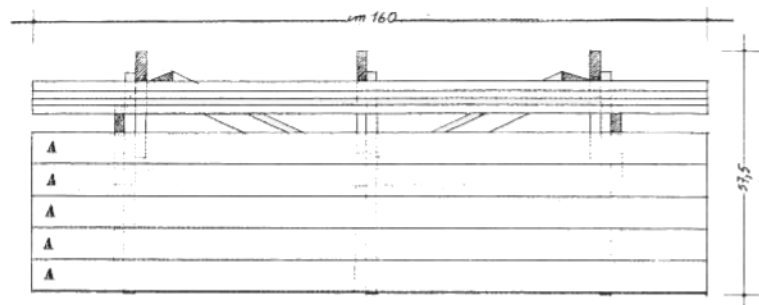
- satisfy the needs of a taste that was starting at the time and for which I provided an ideal alibi, which was that of the «poor» wooden object, the pseudo-crafted object, the ingenuous object of a return to nature;
 - to resolve the real furnishing problems of young students or similar who simply wanted to be able to make what they needed, spending as little as possible;
 - to decorate the country cottage, the second home, in a rustic style, etc.;
- only a very few, 1 or 2% understood the meaning of the experiment.



TAVOLETTE OCCORRENTI

SEZIONE	ES	QUANTITÀ
A	20x25	52
B	"	50
C	"	47
D	5x25	61
E	"	44

1123 x P	SCALA 1:5	5/73
SEDIA		
ENZO ANGILERI - VIALE SANCA 10 - 20123 MILANO - TELEFONO 4193815		

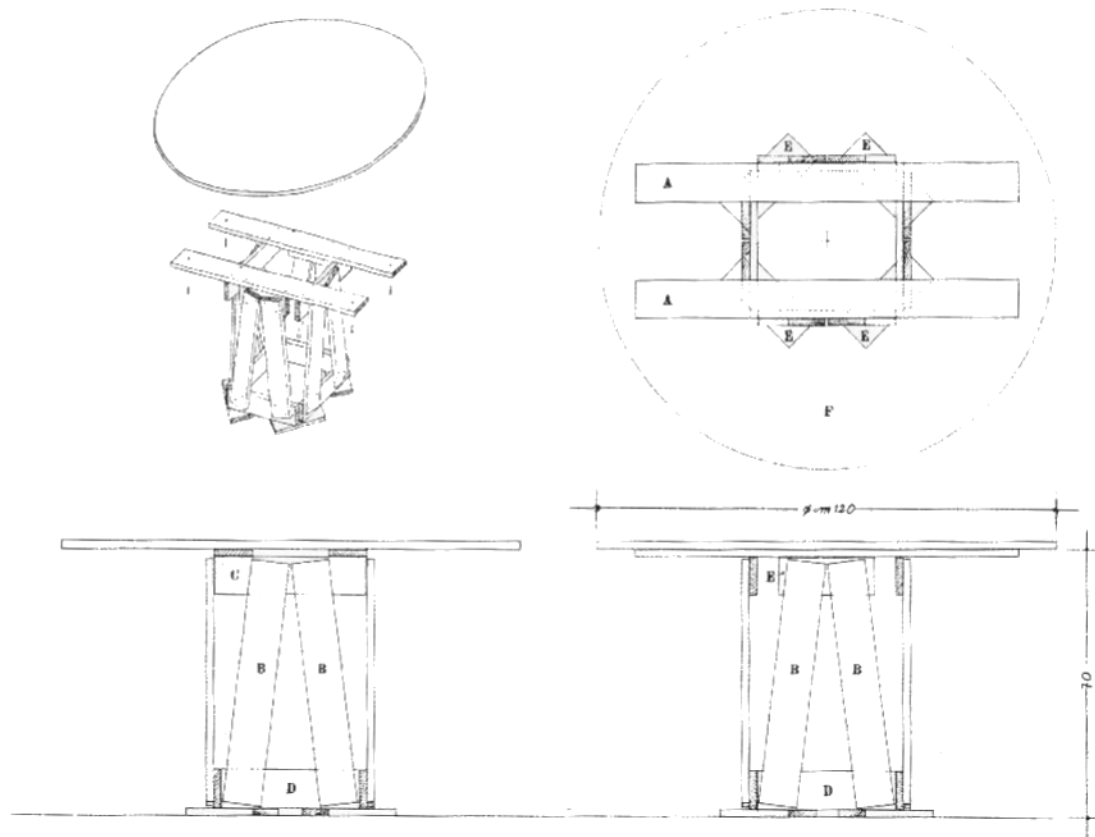


TAVOLETTE OCCORRENTI

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITA'
A 7,5x2,5	160	7
B "	120	1
C "	81	2
D "	75	2
E "	63	1

SEZIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITA'
F 7,5x2,5	45	2
G "	44	5
H "	42	2
I "	33	7
L "	30	1

4123 xS	SCALA 1:5	5/73
PANCA		
ENZO MARI PIAZZALE BARACCA 10 20123 MILANO TELEFONO 4883631		



TAVOLETTE OCCORRENTI

SPESIONE	LUNGHEZZA	QUANTITA'
A	3 x 10	100
B	11	64
C	11	40
D	11	36
E	11	25

SEZIONE	QUANTITA'
E	120 x 2

1123 xH	SCALA 1:5	5/73
TAVOLO ROTONDO		
ENZO MARI - VIALE SANAGLIA 12 - 20123 MILANO - TELEFONO 482085		

A FEW TECHNICAL HINTS

If the planks are 25 mm thick you need nails that are 45 mm long and 2.5 mm in diameter. To prevent the wooden from splitting the tip of the nail should be blunted by hitting it with a hammer before starting. Each joint needs two nails which should never be planted along the same grain of wood.

The current popularity of electric screwdrivers has caused people to lose their ability to use nails and, consequently, to get hold of them easily. Therefore, 45 mm self-threading screws are acceptable.

Then, from a purely formal (symbolic) and "instructive" point of view table tops are "attractive" if they are made by putting several small planks together. From a strictly utilitarian point of view you can use plywood or chipboard.

For the same reasons the constructions are "attractive" if they are left rough, with the saw marks, neither planed nor varnished.